

BANGKOK



ROTATION PHOTOGRAPHER/GETTY IMAGES ©

Bangkok

Formerly the epitome of the steamy Asian metropolis, Bangkok has undergone decades worth of renovations and emerged an international starlet. The Bangkok of today is tidier and easier to navigate than ever before and will impress with awesome urban exploration, dining and nightlife. Supplement your fun with scholarly pursuits such as historic sightseeing and cooking courses. Come here for temples, palaces, malls, restaurants, nightclubs – all super-sized.



In this Chapter

Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace

Wat Pho

Chao Phraya River

Jim Thompson House

Chatuchak Weekend Market

Bangkok Nightlife

Culinary Bangkok

Bangkok Walking Tour



Two Days in Bangkok

Take the **Chao Phraya Express Boat** to explore the temples of **Ko Ratanakosin**, followed by lunch in **Banglamphu**. Stick around for some shopping and imbibing on **Th Khao San**. On the next day visit **Jim Thompson House** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) and wrap up the daylight hours with a Thai massage. Visit a rooftop bar for cocktails, followed by an upscale Thai dinner at **nahm**.

Four Days in Bangkok

Spend a day at **Chatuchak Weekend Market**, enrol in a cooking class, or jump aboard a **long-tail boat** to explore Thonburi's canals. Hit Chinatown for a street-food dinner. Escape Bangkok's chaos with a visit to **Dusit Palace Park**. [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

Splash out at one of Sukhumvit's international restaurants and then hang out with Bangkok's hipsters at Sukhumvit's bars and clubs.



STREET MARKET, TH KHAO SAN / GAVIN HELLIER/GETTY IMAGES ©

Arriving in Bangkok

Suvarnabhumi International Airport The Airport Rail Link (45B, 30 minutes) operates from 6am to midnight. Meter taxis cost 200B to 300B, plus 50B airport surcharge and expressway tolls.

Don Mueang International Airport Meter taxis cost 200B to 500B plus 50B airport surcharge.

Where to Stay

Bangkok is home to a diverse spread of modern hostels, guesthouses and hotels. To make matters better, much of Bangkok's accommodation offers excellent value, and competition is so intense that fat discounts are almost always available.

For more information on the best neighbourhood to stay in, see [here](#).

Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace

Wat Phra Kaew (Temple of the Emerald Buddha) is architecturally fantastic and the spiritual core of Thai Buddhism and the monarchy, symbolically united in what is the country's most holy image, the Emerald Buddha.



WAT PHRA KAEW / PHOTO BY PRASIT CHANSAREEKORN/GETTY IMAGES ©



Great For...



✓ Don't Miss

The **Ramakian Murals** depict the *Ramakian* (the Thai version of the Indian *Ramayana* epic) in its entirety.

i Need to Know

Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (วัดพระแก้ว, พระบรมมหาราชวัง; Th Na Phra Lan; admission 500B; 🕒 8.30am-3.30pm; [FREE](#) Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier)

✂ Take a Break

Pa Aew is a basic, open-air curry stall but it's one of our favourite places to eat in this part of town.

★ Top Tip

Guides can be hired at the ticket kiosk; ignore anyone outside. An audio guide can be rented for 200B for two hours.

Wat Phra Kaew

Wat Phra Kaew gleams and glitters with so much colour and glory that its earthly foundations seem barely able to resist the celestial pull. Attached to the temple complex is the former royal residence, once a sealed city of intricate ritual and social stratification, although most of it is off-limits to visitors.

The ground was consecrated in 1782, the first year of Bangkok rule, and is today Bangkok's biggest tourist attraction and a pilgrimage destination for devout Buddhists and nationalists. The 94.5-hectare grounds encompass more than 100 buildings that represent 200 years of royal history and architectural experimentation. Wat Phra Kaew and the Grand Palace are best reached either by a short walk south from Banglamphu, via Sanam Luang, or by Chao Phraya Express Boat to Chang Pier or Maharaj Pier. From the Siam Sq area (in front of the MBK Center, Th Phra Ram I), take bus 47.



YAKSHA (GUARDIAN GIANT) / RMNUNES/GETTY IMAGES ©

Ramakian Murals

Outside the main *bòht* (ordination hall) is a stone statue of the Chinese goddess of mercy, Kuan Im. In the 2km-long cloister that defines the perimeter of the complex are 178 murals depicting the *Ramakian* (the Thai version of the Indian *Ramayana* epic) in its entirety, beginning at the north gate and moving clockwise around the compound. If the temple grounds seem overrun by tourists, the mural area is usually mercifully quiet and shady.

Emerald Buddha

Upon entering Wat Phra Kaew you'll meet the *yaksha*, brawny guardian giants from the *Ramakian*. Beyond them is a courtyard where the central *bòht* houses the Emerald Buddha. The spectacular ornamentation inside and out does an excellent job of distracting first-time visitors from paying their respects to the

image. Here's why: the Emerald Buddha is only 66cm tall and sits so high above worshippers in the main temple building that the gilded shrine is more striking than the small figure it cradles. No one knows exactly where it comes from or who sculpted it, but it first appeared on record in 15th-century Chiang Rai (in northern Thailand). Photography inside the *bòht* is not permitted.

Grand Palace

Adjoining Wat Phra Kaew is the Grand Palace (Phra Borom Maharatchawang), a former royal residence that is today only used on ceremonial occasions. Visitors can survey a portion of the Grand Palace grounds, but are allowed to enter only one of the remaining palace buildings.

Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace

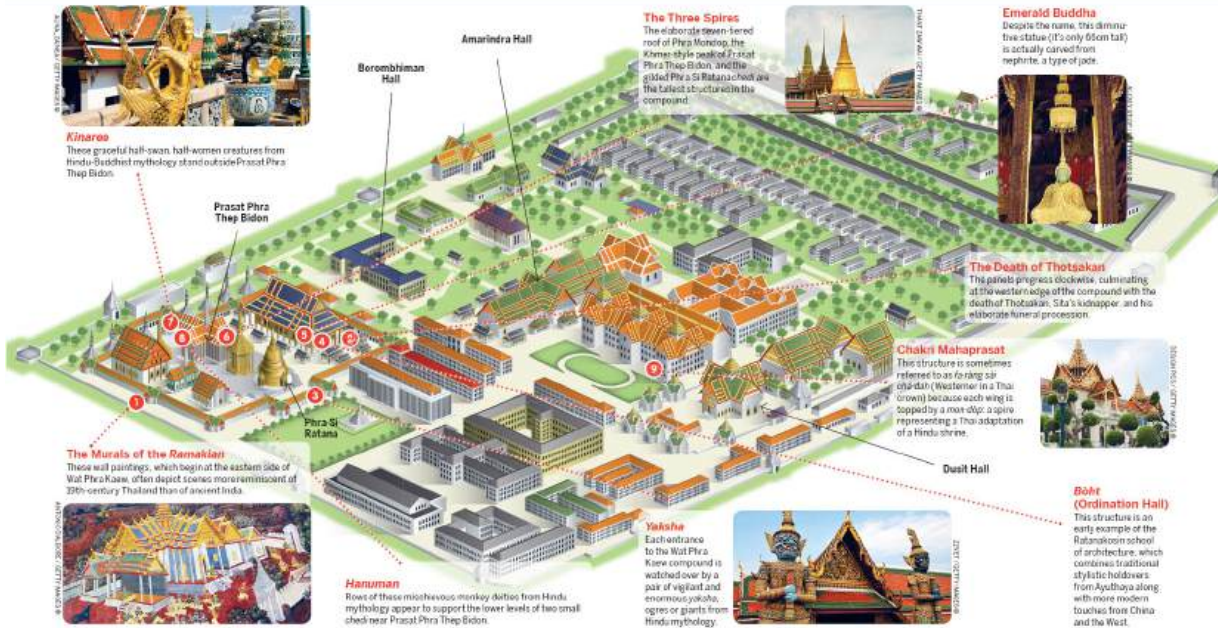
EXPLORE BANGKOK'S PREMIER MONUMENTS TO RELIGION AND REGENCY

The first area tourists enter is the Buddhist temple compound generally referred to as Wat Phra Kaew. A covered walkway surrounds the area, the inner walls of which are decorated with the **murals of the Ramakian** ① and ②. Originally painted during the reign of Rama I (1782-1809), the murals, which depict the Hindu epic the *Ramayana*, span 178 panels that describe the struggles of Rama to rescue his kidnapped wife, Sita.

After taking in the story, pass through one of the gateways guarded by **yaksha** ③ to the inner compound. The most important structure here is the **bōht, or ordination hall** ④, which houses the **Emerald Buddha** ⑤.

Head east to the so-called Upper Terrace, an elevated area home to the **spires of the three primary chedi** ⑥. The middle structure, Phra Mondop, is used to house Buddhist manuscripts. This area is also home to several of Wat Phra Kaew's noteworthy mythical beings, including beckoning **kinaree** ⑦ and several grinning **Hanuman** ⑧.

Proceed through the western gate to the compound known as the Grand Palace. Few of the buildings here are open to the public. The most noteworthy structure is **Chakri Mahaprasat** ⑨. Built in 1882, the exterior of the hall is a unique blend of Western and traditional Thai architecture.



Kinaree
These graceful half-swan, half-woman creatures from Hindu-Buddhist mythology stand outside Prasad Phra Thep Bidon.



The Murals of the Ramakian
These wall paintings, which begin at the eastern side of Wat Phra Kaew, often depict scenes more reminiscent of 19th-century Thailand than of ancient India.

Hanuman
Rows of these mischievous monkey deities from Hindu mythology appear to support the lower levels of two small chedis near Prasad Phra Thep Bidon.

The Three Spires
The elaborate seven-tiered roof of Phra Mondop, the Khmer-style pavilion of Phra Thep Bidon, and the gilded Phra Si Ratana chedi are the tallest structures in the compound.



Emerald Buddha
Despite the name, this diminutive statue (it's only 66cm tall) is actually carved from nephrite, a type of jade.



The Death of Thotsakan
The panels progress clockwise, culminating at the western edge of the compound with the death of Thotsakan, Sita's kidnapper, and his elaborate funeral procession.



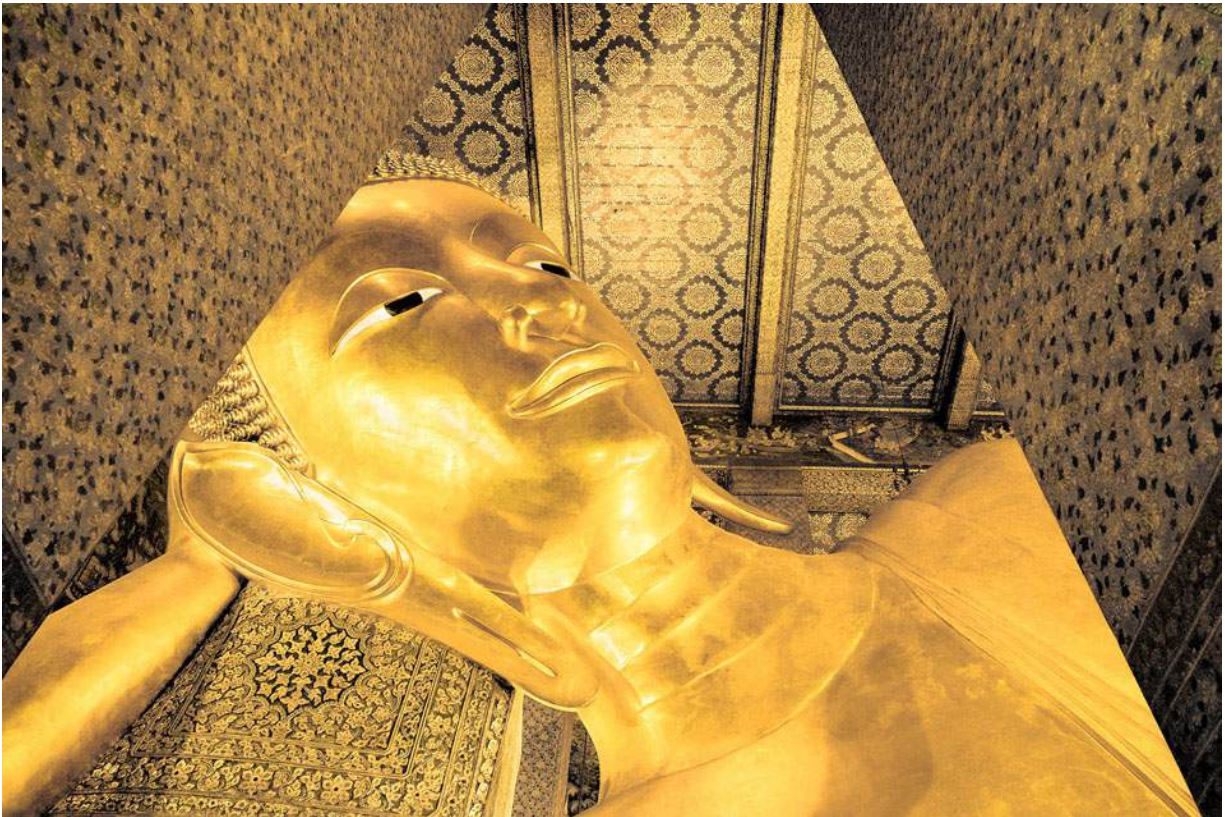
Chakri Mahaprasat
This structure is sometimes referred to as *fa rang sai chad-dah* (Westerner in a Thai crown) because each wing is topped by a man-elephant figure representing a Thai adaptation of a Hindu shrine.



Bōht (Ordination Hall)
This structure is an early example of the Rattanakosin school of architecture, which combines traditional stylistic holdovers from Ayutthaya along with more modern touches from China and the West.

Wat Pho

Of all Bangkok's temples, Wat Pho is arguably the one most worth visiting, for both its remarkable Reclining Buddha image and its sprawling, stupa-studded grounds. The temple compound houses the oldest and largest wát in Bangkok and the largest collection of Buddha images in Thailand.



RECLINING BUDDHA / MOAI99/GETTY IMAGES ©



Great For...



☑ Don't Miss

The Reclining Buddha, the granite statues and the massage pavilions.

i Need to Know

Wat Pho **MAP** **GOOGLE MAP** (วัดโพธิ์/วัดพระเชตุพน, Wat Phra Chetuphon; Th Sanam Chai; admission 100B; 🕒 8.30am-6.30pm; **FREE** Tien Pier)

✂ Take a Break

Sip a cocktail at Amorosa, while enjoying views of the river and Wat Arun.

★ Top Tip

Enter via Th Chetuphon or Th Sanam Chai to avoid the touts and tour groups at the main entrance on Th Thai Wang.

Reclining Buddha

In the northwest corner of the site you'll find Wat Pho's main attraction, the enormous Reclining Buddha. The figure was originally commissioned by Rama III (King Phranangkla; r 1824–51), and illustrates the passing of the Buddha into nirvana. It is made of plaster around a brick core and finished in gold leaf, which gives it a serene luminescence that keeps you looking, and looking again, from different angles.

Phra Ubosot

Phra Ubosot, the compound's main ordination hall or *bòht*, is constructed in Ayuthaya style and is strikingly more subdued than Wat Phra Kaew's. A temple has stood on this site since the 16th century, but in 1781 Rama I ordered the original Wat Photharam to be completely rebuilt as part of his new capital. Rama I's remains are interred in the base of the presiding Buddha figure in Phra Ubosot. The images on display in the four *wí·hăhn* (sanctuaries) surrounding Phra Ubosot are worth investigation, as is a low marble wall with 152 bas-reliefs depicting scenes from the *Ramakian*. You'll recognise some of these figures when you exit the temple past the hawkers with mass-produced rubbings for sale: these are made from cement casts based on Wat Pho's reliefs.



Royal Chedi

On the western side of the grounds is a collection of four towering tiled *chedi* (stupa) commemorating the first four Chakri kings. The surrounding wall was built on the orders of Rama IV (King Mongkut; r 1851–68), who for reasons we can only speculate about decided he didn't want any future kings joining the memorial. Among the compound's additional 91 smaller *chedi* are clusters containing the ashes of lesser royal descendants.

Massage Pavilions

A small pavilion west of Phra Ubosot has Unesco-awarded inscriptions detailing the tenets of traditional Thai massage. These and other similar inscriptions led Wat Pho to be regarded as Thailand's first university. Today it maintains that tradition as the national headquarters for the teaching and preservation of traditional Thai medicine, including Thai massage. The famous school has two massage pavilions ([Click here](#)), located within the temple area and additional rooms within the training facility ([Click here](#)), outside the temple.

Gardens

Small Chinese-style rock gardens and hill islands interrupt the compound's numerous tiled courtyards providing shade, greenery and quirky decorations depicting daily life. Keep an eye out for the distinctive rockery festooned with figures of the hermit Khao Mor – who is credited with inventing yoga – in various healing positions.

Wat Pho

A WALK THROUGH THE BIG BUDDHAS OF WAT PHO

The logical starting place is the main **wi-hahn** (sanctuary), home to Wat Pho's centrepiece, the immense **Reclining Buddha** ❶. Apart from its huge size, note the **mother-of-pearl inlays** ❷ on the soles of the statue's feet. The interior walls of the **wi-hahn** are covered with murals depicting previous lives of the

Buddha, and along the south side of the structure are 108 bronze monk bowls; for 20B you can buy 108 coins, each of which is dropped in a bowl for good luck.

Exit the **wi-hahn** and head east via the two **stone giants** ❸ who guard the gateway to the rest of the compound. Directly south of these are the four towering **royal chedi** ❹.

Continue east, passing through two consecutive **galleries of Buddha**

statues ❺ linking four **wi-hahn**, two of which contain notable Sukhothai-era Buddha statues; these comprise the exterior of **Phra Ubosot** ❻, the immense ordination hall that is Wat Pho's second-most noteworthy structure. The base of the building is surrounded by bas-relief inscriptions, and inside is the notable Buddha statue, **Phra Buddha Deva Patimakorn** ❼.

Wat Pho is often referred to as Thailand's first university, a tradition that continues today in an associated traditional Thai medicine school and, at the compound's eastern extent, two **massage pavilions** ❽.

Interspersed throughout the eastern half of the compound are several additional minor **chedi** and rock gardens.



Phra Ubosot
Built during the reign of Rama I, the imposing light (ordination hall) as it stands today is the result of renovations dating back to the reign of Rama II (c. 1824–51).

Southern **wi-hahn**



Buddha Galleries
The two series of covered hallways that surround the Phra Ubosot feature no fewer than 394 gilded Buddha images, many of which display classic Ayutthaya or Sukhothai features.



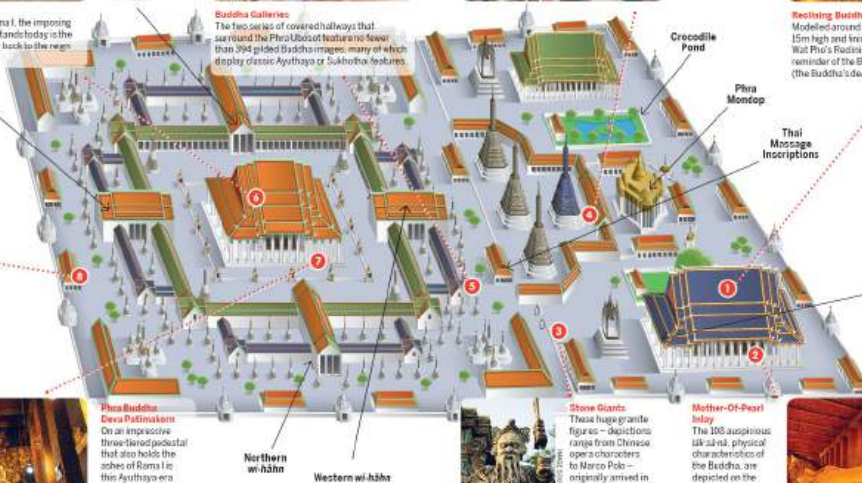
Royal Chedi
Decorated in colored tiles in a classic example of Ratanakosin style, these four chedi are meant to represent the first four kings of the Chakri dynasty.



Reclining Buddha
Modelled around a brick core 46m long and 15m high and inlaid in plaster and gold leaf, Wat Pho's Reclining Buddha is an imposing reminder of the Buddha's passing into nirvana (the Buddha's death).



Massage Pavilions
If you're hot and footsore, the two air-conditioned massage pavilions are a welcome way to cool down while experiencing high-quality and relatively inexpensive Thai massage.



Crocodile Pond

Phra Mondop

Thai Massage Inscriptions

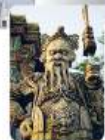
Main **wi-hahn**



Phra Buddha Deva Patimakorn
On an impressive three-tiered pedestal that also holds the soles of Rama I is this Ayutthaya-era Buddha statue originally brought to the temple by the monarch.

Northern **wi-hahn**

Western **wi-hahn**



Stone Giants
These huge granite figures – deities range from Chinese opera characters to Marco Polo – are originally arrived in Thailand in the 19th century as ballast aboard Chinese junk.

Mother-Of-Pearl Inlay
The 108 auspicious likai-nai, physical characteristics of the Buddha, are depicted on the soles of the feet of the Reclining Buddha.



Chao Phraya River

The River of Kings is the symbolic lifeblood of the Thai nation. Revered riverside temples stand sentry as boats and barges industriously move cargo and passengers, and cool breezes provide evening refreshment.



CHAO PHRAYA RIVER, WITH WAT ARUN IN THE BACKGROUND / JON ARNOLD/GETTY IMAGES ©



Great For...



☒ Don't Miss

Catch the Chao Phraya Express Boat as the sun sets across this throbbing metropolis.

i Need to Know

Tour the river and riverside attractions aboard chartered long-tail boats (1½ to two hours, 1300-1500B) or the Chao Phraya Express commuter boats.

✂ Take a Break

Make a dinner date with the river at **Khinlom Chom Sa-Phan**

MAP **GOOGLE MAP** (☎ 02 628 8382; www.khinlomchomsaphan.com;

11/6 Soi 3, Th Samsen; mains 95-2500B; 🕒 11.30am-midnight;

FREE Thewet Pier).

★ Top Tip

Women shouldn't sit in the last seats on the commuter boats; these are reserved for monks.

Wat Arun

Claiming a powerful riverside position, **Wat Arun** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (วัดอรุณฯ; www.watarun.net; off Th Arun Amarin; admission 50B; 🕒 8am-6pm; [FREE](#) cross-river ferry from Tien Pier) marks the rebirth of the Thai nation after the fall of Ayuthaya to the invading Burmese army in the 1700s. The temple's facade is decorated with delicate porcelain mosaics, a common temple adornment from the days when Chinese porcelain was used for ship ballasts.

Thonburi's Canals

Bangkok's past as the Venice of the East lives, bathes and plays along Thonburi's network of canals, including Khlong Bangkok Noi and Khlong Mon. Traditional homes are built on stilts with front doors leading to the water.





TALING CHAN FLOATING MARKET / KARENMASSIER/GETTY IMAGES ©

Royal Barges National Museum

Travel by boat used to be a majestic affair. Historic vessels dating back to the Ayuthaya period are on display at the **Royal Barges National Museum** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (พิพิธภัณฑ์สถานแห่งชาติ เรือพระราชพิธี/เรือพระที่นั่ง; Khlong Bangkok Noi or 80/1 Th Arun Amarin; admission 100B, camera 100B; 🕒 9am-5pm; [FREE](#) Phra Pin Klao Bridge Pier).

Suphannahong (the king's personal barge) is bestowed with a huge swan head carved into the bow. Lesser barges feature bows that are carved into other Hindu-Buddhist mythological shapes such as the *naga* (mythical sea serpent) and *garuda* (Vishnu's bird mount).

Floating Market

The nearly extinct floating markets (*đà-làht nám*) have been rescued by nostalgic Thais and tourists. **Taling Chan Floating Market** (ตลาดน้ำตลิ่งชัน; Khlong Bangkok Noi, Thonburi; 🕒 7am-4pm Sat & Sun; [S](#) Wongwian Yai exit 3 & taxi), located along Khlong Bangkok Noi, is a hybrid market with fruit vendors on the road and floating docks serving as informal dining rooms. Meals are prepared aboard tethered canoes.

Ko Kret

An easy rural getaway, Ko Kret is a car-free island and home to the Mon people, known for their hand-thrown terracotta pots. Locals flock to Ko Kret on weekends to snack and shop. Ko Kret is in Nonthaburi, about 15km north of central Bangkok. Take bus 166 from the Victory Monument or a taxi to Pak Kret, before boarding the cross-river ferry (2B, from 5am to 9pm) that leaves from Wat Sanam Neua.

Jim Thompson House

The former home of an American silk entrepreneur is a beautiful repository for Thai art and architecture. On display are museum-quality examples of Thai craftsmanship, Buddhist sculpture and textiles.



INTERIOR OF JIM THOMPSON HOUSE / SAIKO3P/SHUTTERSTOCK ©



Great For...



✓ Don't Miss

Wandering the lushly landscaped grounds.

i Need to Know

([MAP](#); www.jimthompsonhouse.com; 6 Soi Kasem San 2; adult/student 150/100B; ⌚ 9am-6pm, compulsory tours every 20 min; **FREE** klong boat to Sapan Hua Chang Pier, **S** National Stadium exit 1)

🍴 Take a Break

MBK Food Island ([MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)) (6th fl, MBK Center, cnr Th Phra Ram I & Th Phayathai; mains 35-150B; ⌚ 10am-10pm; ❄️🍷; **S** National Stadium exit 4) is a quintessential mall food court selling Thai and international dishes.

★ Top Tip

Read *The Ideal Man* by Joshua Kurlantzick for a profile of Jim Thompson.

A socialite and former spy, Jim Thompson's life is as intriguing as his belongings. He served briefly in the Office of Strategic Services (the forerunner to the CIA) in Thailand during WWII. Settling in Bangkok after the war, he established a successful Thai silk export business, introducing the textile to international fashion houses. He mysteriously disappeared in 1967 while out for a walk in Malaysia's Cameron Highlands. His disappearance was never explained and some suspect foul play.

Art

A collector with eclectic tastes, Thompson bought art and antiques from travelling merchants and neighbouring countries. He collected objects that were not well known at the time, including from the Dvaravati period.

Architecture

As an architect, Thompson was drawn to traditional Thai houses instead of the modern, Western-style homes popular at the time. He collected six teak houses from different regions in the country as a showcase for his art collection. Some of the houses were brought from Ayuthaya, while others were transported across the canal from Baan Khrua. The homes were given a landscaped jungle garden to further highlight Thailand's natural beauty. The home, however, is organised like a Western residence with an entrance hall and all rooms arranged on the same level overlooking the terrace and the canal.

Baan Khrua

Just across the canal is the silk-weaving community of **Baan Khrua**

  (บ้านครัว;  klong boat to Sapan Hua Chang Pier,

 Ratchathewi exit 1, National Stadium exit 1). This neighborhood was

settled by Cham Muslims from Cambodia and Vietnam, who relocated to Bangkok after fighting on the side of the Thai king during the wars of the end of the 18th century. Their silk-weaving skills attracted the attention of Jim Thompson in the 1950s and '60s when he hired the weavers for his burgeoning silk export business. Since then commercial silk production and many of the original families have moved elsewhere, but two family-run outfits, **Phamai Baan Krua**   (www.phamaibaankrua.com; Soi 9, Soi Phaya Nak; 🕒 8.30am-5pm;  klong boat to Sapan Hua Chang Pier,  Ratchathewi exit 1, National Stadium exit 1) and **Aood Bankrua Thai Silk**   (📞 02 215 9864; Soi 9, Soi Phaya Nak; 🕒 9am-8pm;  klong boat to Sapan Hua Chang Pier,  Ratchathewi exit 1, National Stadium exit 1), continue the tradition. Baan Khrua can be reached by the bridge over the canal at the end of Soi Kasem San 3.

Chatuchak Weekend Market

An outdoor market on steroids, Chatuchak Weekend Market sells everything under the sun. Vendors are packed into claustrophobic warrens. It is crowded and chaotic but one-of-a-kind.



STALLS SELLING ARTS AND CRAFTS / MADDOG99/SHUTTERSTOCK ©



Great For...



☑ Don't Miss

If you aren't in town on the weekend, visit **Or Tor Kor Market**

MAP **GOOGLE MAP** (องค์กรตลาดเพื่อเกษตรกร; Th Kamphaengphet 1; 🕒 8am-6pm; **M** Kamphaeng Phet exit 3), a huge fruit and vegetable market.

📍 Need to Know

Chatuchak Weekend Market **MAP** **GOOGLE MAP** (ตลาดนัดจตุจักร, Talat Nat Jatujak; www.chatuchak.org; Th Phahonyothin; 🕒 9am-6pm Sat & Sun; **M** Chatuchak Park exit 1, Kamphaeng Phet exits 1 & 2, **S** Mo Chit exit 1)

🍴 Take a Break

Sections 6 and 8 have food and drink vendors, a necessary antidote to Chatuchak fatigue.

★ Top Tip

Come early to beat the crowds and the heat. Or check out the low-key Friday nights (8pm to midnight) for clothing and live music.

A little pre-planning goes a long way. Nancy Chandler's *Map of Bangkok* has a handy schematic map and the clock tower provides an essential landmark.

Antiques, Handicrafts & Souvenirs

Section 1 is the place to go for Buddha statues, old LPs and other random antiques. More secular arts and crafts, such as musical instruments and hill-tribe items, can be found in Sections 25 and 26.

Clothing & Accessories

Clothing dominates most of Chatuchak, starting in Section 8 and continuing through the even-numbered sections to 24. Sections 5 and 6 deal in used clothing for every youth subculture, from punks to cowboys, while Soi 7, where it transects Sections 12 and 14, is heavy on hip-hop and skate fashions. More sophisticated independent labels can be found in Sections 2 and 3, while tourist-sized clothes and textiles are in Sections 8 and 10.





THAI BRACELETS / MICHAEL LUHRENBURG/GETTY IMAGES ©

Housewares & Decor

The western edge of the market, particularly Sections 8 to 26, specialises in housewares, from cheap plastic buckets to expensive brass woks. This area is a particularly good place to stock up on inexpensive Thai ceramics, ranging from celadon to the traditional rooster-themed bowls from Lampang. For less utilitarian goods, Section 7 is a virtual open-air gallery with stalls selling Bangkok-themed murals and other unique art work. Burmese lacquerware can be found in Section 10, while Section 26 has dusty collections of real and reproduction antiques from Thailand and Myanmar.

Eating & Drinking

Lots of Thai-style eating and snacking will stave off Chatuchak rage, and numerous food stalls set up shop between Sections 6 and 8. Long-standing favourites include Foontalop, a popular Isan restaurant; Café Ice, a Western-Thai fusion joint that does good, if overpriced, *pàt tai* (fried noodles) and tasty fruit shakes; Toh-Plue, which does all the Thai standards; and Saman Islam, a Thai-Muslim restaurant that serves a tasty chicken biryani. Viva 8 features a DJ and, when we stopped by, a chef making huge platters of paella. And as evening draws near, down a beer at Viva's, a cafe-bar that features live music.

TOP EXPERIENCE

Bangkok Nightlife

Bangkok wins all the awards in the nightlife category, embracing every party trend invented, from sweaty bars and sophisticated clubs to late-night dance parties.



SKY BAR / VISIONS OF OUR LAND/GETTY IMAGES ©

Great For...



☒ **Don't Miss**

Toasting the stars from a rooftop bar.

Need to Know

Bars and clubs close at midnight, 1am or 2am, depending on their designation and if the rules are enforced.

Take a Break

A good time for Thais always involves food and most bars have tasty snacks to accommodate a liquid date.

Top Tip

Thais drink their beer with ice to keep it cool and to help hydrate.

Bars

Bangkok's watering holes range from barebones beer gardens with plastic chairs to chic cocktail dens. Backpackers and young Thais congregate in Th Khao San. Romantic evenings can be found at riverside restaurants or rooftop bars. Th Sukhumvit has an eclectic collection of expats and hipster Thais. Only the rooftop bars enforce a dress code: no shorts or sandals.

- **WTF**   (www.wtfbangkok.com; 7 Soi 51, Th Sukhumvit; ⌚ 6pm-1am Tue-Sun; 📶; 🚶 Thong Lo exit 3) A sophisticated yet friendly local boozier.

- **Hippie de Bar**   (www.facebook.com/hippie.debar; 46 Th Khao San; ⌚ 3pm-2am; 🆓 Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) This is a fun, retro-themed bar in the middle of Th Khao San.

- **Moon Bar**   (www.banyantree.com/en/web/banyantree/ap-thailand-bangkok/vertigo-and-moon-bar; 61st fl, Banyan Tree Hotel, 21/100 Th Sathon Tai/South; ⌚ 5pm-1am; 🚶 Lumphini exit 2) Stunning views make this our fave of Bangkok rooftop bars.

- **Sky Bar** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.lebua.com/sky-bar; 63rd fl, State Tower, 1055 Th Silom; 🕒 6pm-1am; [FREE](#) Sathon/Central Pier, [S](#) Saphan Taksin exit 3) Go on, order a 'hangoverini' at this movie star rooftop bar.
- **Amorosa** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.arunresidence.com; rooftop, Arun Residence, 36-38 Soi Pratu Nokying; 🕒 5pm-midnight Mon-Thu, to 1am Fri-Sun; [FREE](#) Tien Pier) Sip the splendour of old Bangkok from this rooftop cocktail bar.
- **Smalls** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (186/3 Soi Suan Phlu; 🕒 8.30pm-late; [M](#) Lumpini exit 2 & taxi) Cheeky new bar that feels like an old favourite.

Clubs

Bangkok's club scene is fickle, and venues that were pulling in thousands a night last year might be just a vague memory this year. Clubs also tend to heave on certain nights – Friday and Saturday, during a visit from a foreign DJ, or for a night dedicated to the music flavour of the month – then hibernate every other night.

The streets that extend from Th Sukhumvit are home to many of Bangkok's most popular clubs. Ravers of uni age tend to head to Soi 63/Ekamai, while the pampered elite play at Soi 55/Thong Lor, and expats, sexpats and tourists head to the clubs around Soi 11.

- **Route 66** (www.route66club.com; 29/33-48 RCA/Royal City Ave; admission 300B; 🕒 8pm-2am; [M](#) Phra Ram 9 exit 3 & taxi) Long-standing megaclub.
- **Arena 10** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (Soi Thong Lor 10/Soi Ekamai 5; [S](#) Ekkamai exit 2 & taxi) The current club queen.

Live Music

Bangkok is the music capital of a musically inclined country. The city has a thriving indie music scene and a cover band for every genre, especially reggae.

Banglamphu is home to Bangkok's greatest concentration of live music bars. The western stretch of Th Phra Athit in particular is home to half a dozen back-to-back, pint-sized music pubs that offer lots of loud Thai pop, but not a whole lot of breathing room. Others are outside of central Bangkok.

- **Brick Bar** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.brickbarkhaosan.com; basement, Buddy Lodge, 265 Th Khao San; admission Sat & Sun 150B; 🕒 8pm-1.30am; [FREE](#) Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) Live-music den, famous among locals for dancing on the tables.

- **Ad Here the 13th** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.facebook.com/adhere13thbluesbar; 13 Th Samsen; 🕒 6pm-midnight; [FREE](#) Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) A Bangkok blues veteran.

- **Brown Sugar** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.brownsugarbangkok.com; 469 Th Phra Sumen; 🕒 5pm-1am Tue-Thu, to 2am Sat & Sun; [FREE](#) klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier, Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) A jazz matron with a new home in Banglamphu.

- **Living Room** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (☎ 02 649 8888; www.thelivingroomatbangkok.com/en; Level 1, Sheraton Grande Sukhumvit, 250 Th Sukhumvit; 🕒 6pm-midnight; [M](#) Sukhumvit exit 3, [S](#) Asok exit 2) As the name implies, live jazz in a comfortable setting.

- **Raintree** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (Soi Ruam Chit; 🕒 6pm-1am Mon-Sat; [S](#) Victory Monument exit 2) Thai folk music in a rustic 'country bar.

- **Parking Toys' Watt** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.facebook.com/Wattparkingtoys; 164 Soi Sun Wichai 14; 🕒 6pm-2am; [S](#) Ekkamai exit 4 & taxi) Quirky live music spot.

After-Hours Spots

Speakeasies have sprung up all over the city, so follow the crowds. Here are a few reliable night owls.

- **Wong's Place** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (27/3 Soi Si Bamphen; 🕒 9pm-late Tue-Sun; [M](#) Lumphini exit 1) Open from midnight until the last punter crawls out.

- **The Bank** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (3rd fl, 44 Th Chakraphatdi Phong; ⌚ 6pm-late; **FREE** Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) Puff on *shisha* or dance into the wee hours on Th Khao San.
- **Narz** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.narzclubbangkok.net; 112 Soi 23; admission from 400B; ⌚ 9pm-2am; **M** Sukhumvit exit 2, **S** Asok exit 3) Clubbers rave 'til dawn.
- **Levels** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.levelsclub.com; 6th fl, Aloft, 35 Soi 11, Th Sukhumvit; admission 500B; ⌚ 9pm-late; **S** Nana exit 3) Soi 11 late-night spot.



TH KHAO SAN / DIDIER MARTI/GETTY IMAGES ©

★ Take a Break

Perennial favourite Hemlock, on Th Phra Athit, offers an eclectic menu, with old dishes from aristocratic kitchens across the country and several meat-free items.

LGBT Scene

Bangkok has a notoriously pink vibe to it. Unlike elsewhere in Southeast Asia, homosexuality is not criminalised in Thailand and the general attitude remains extremely laissez-faire.

- **Telephone Pub** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.telephonepub.com; 114/11-13 Soi 4, Th Silom; 🕒 6pm-1am; 📶; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 1) An old favourite in Bangkok's pinkest zone.

- **Balcony** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.balconypub.com; 86-88 Soi 4, Th Silom; 🕒 5.30pm-2am; 📶; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 1) Streetside watering hole.

- **Maggie Choo's** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.facebook.com/maggiechoos; basement, Novotel Bangkok Fenix Silom, 320 Th Silom; 🕒 7.30pm-2am Sun-Thu, to 3am Fri & Sat; **S** Surasak exit 1) Sunday is gay day.

- **DJ Station** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.dj-station.com; 8/6-8 Soi 2, Th Silom; admission from 150B; 🕒 10pm-2am; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 1) Bangkok's most popular gay club.

- **G Bangkok** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (Guys on Display; Soi 2/1, Th Silom; admission 300B; 🕒 11pm-late; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 1) Where to go after-hours in Silom.

- **Castro** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (www.facebook.com/Castro.rca.bangkok; RCA/Royal City Ave; admission 200B; 🕒 9.30pm-2am; **M** Phra Ram 9 exit 3 & taxi) The only gay destination in RCA.

★ Did You Know?

Officially, Bangkok's bars and clubs are supposed to close by midnight, a rule that's been enforced lately, though venues in designated 'entertainment areas' open until 1am or 2am.

Culinary Bangkok

Nowhere else is the Thai reverence for food more evident than in Bangkok. Life appears to be a never-ending meal with a little bit of work and commuting thrown into the mix. For more Eating options, see [here](#).



EGG NOODLE SOUP WITH WONTONS / QUYNH ANH NGUYEN/GETTY IMAGES ©



MBK CENTER HAS AN EXTENSIVE FOOD COURT / SYLVAIN SONNET/GETTY IMAGES ©

Great For...



☒ Don't Miss

You don't need a restaurant and linens to have a fine meal in this city. Bangkok foodies adore several famous street vendors.

i Need to Know

Restaurants are generally open from 10am to 8pm. Street vendors are prohibited from operating on Monday.

✂ Take a Break

Mall food courts offer a great introduction to Thai street food.

★ Top Tip

Thais use their spoon like a fork, held with the right hand, and hold the fork in the left hand. They only use chopsticks for noodle dishes.

Dining Scene

All of Thailand's culinary traditions converge in Bangkok. Simple market meals fuel the working class and transform the sidewalk into a communal dining room. High-end makeovers of Thai classics and royal recipes define the fine-dining scene. Mum-and-pop restaurants anchor a neighborhood, be it an immigrant community from Arabia or from southern Thailand.

Bangkok's Must-Have Meals

- **Pàt tai** Thailand's famous noodle dish at **Thip Samai** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (313 Th Mahachai; mains 50-250B; 🕒 5pm-2am; [FREE](#) klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier).
- **Gǎo•ay dǎe•o reua** Pork/beef 'boat noodle' soups at **Bharani** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (Sansab Boat Noodle; 96/14 Soi 23, Th Sukhumvit; mains 60-250B; 🕒 11am-10pm; ❄️; [M](#) Sukhumvit exit 2, [S](#) Asok exit 3).
- **Mèe gròrp** A palace recipe for crispy noodles at **Chote Chitr** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (146 Th Phraeng Phuthon; mains 60-200B; 🕒 11am-10pm; [FREE](#) klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier).
- **Kôw man gàì** Chicken rice at **Boon Tong Kiat Singapore Hainanese Chicken Rice** ([MAP](#); 440/5 Soi 55/Thong Lor, Th Sukhumvit; mains 65-300B; 🕒 10am-10pm; ❄️; [S](#) Thong Lo exit 3 & taxi).
- **Or sòo-an** Oyster crepe, a Bangkok Chinatown staple, at **Nai Mong Hoi Thod** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (539 Th Phlap Phla Chai; mains 50-70B; 🕒 5-10pm Tue-Sun; [FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi).

- **Má-đà-bà** Meat-filled flatbread, a Southeast Asian Muslim favourite, at **Roti-Mataba** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (136 Th Phra Athit; dishes 19-115B; 🕒 9am-10pm Tue-Sun; ❄️🔪; **FREE** Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier).



STREET-FOOD VENDOR / DESIGN PICS/RAY LASKOWITZ/GETTY IMAGES ©

Cooking Courses

Better than a souvenir, Thai cooking courses teach students how to recreate standard dishes back home. Courses are half-day and include a recipe book and lunch.

- **Helping Hands** (📞 080 434 8686; www.cookingwithpoo.com; 1500B; 🕒 lessons 8.30am-1pm)
- **Silom Thai Cooking School** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (📞 084 726 5669; www.bangkokthaicooking.com; 68 Soi 13, Th Silom; courses 1000B; 🕒 lessons 9am-1pm, 1.40-5.30pm & 6-9pm; 📍 Chong Nonsi exit 3)
- **Bangkok Bold Cooking Studio** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (📞 098 829 4310; www.bangkokbold.com; 503 Th Phra Sumen; courses 2000B;

🕒 lessons 9am-1pm & 2-5pm; 🆓 klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier)

Bangkok Walking Tour

Stroll around the former royal district of Ko Ratanakosin. Start early to beat the heat, dress modestly for the temples, and ignore shopping advice from well-dressed touts. Start Wat Phra Kaew
Distance 5km
Duration 3 hours

Take a Break...Savoey Provides an air-conditioned rest stop.

4 Return to the east bank to explore the classic architecture and riverside accoutrements in the narrow alleyway of Trok Tha Wang.

3 Catch the cross-river ferry from Tien Pier to the military-looking **Wat Arun** temple, boasting a Khmer-style *chedi* (stupa).

5 Wander along Trok Mahathat, the alley leading to the **Amulet Market**, to appreciate how extensive the market for small talismans is.

6 Exit at Th Phra Chan, and continue east until you reach the Sanam Luang (Royal Field), which hosts the annual Ploughing Ceremony.

Gold garuda decoration at Wat Phra Kaew

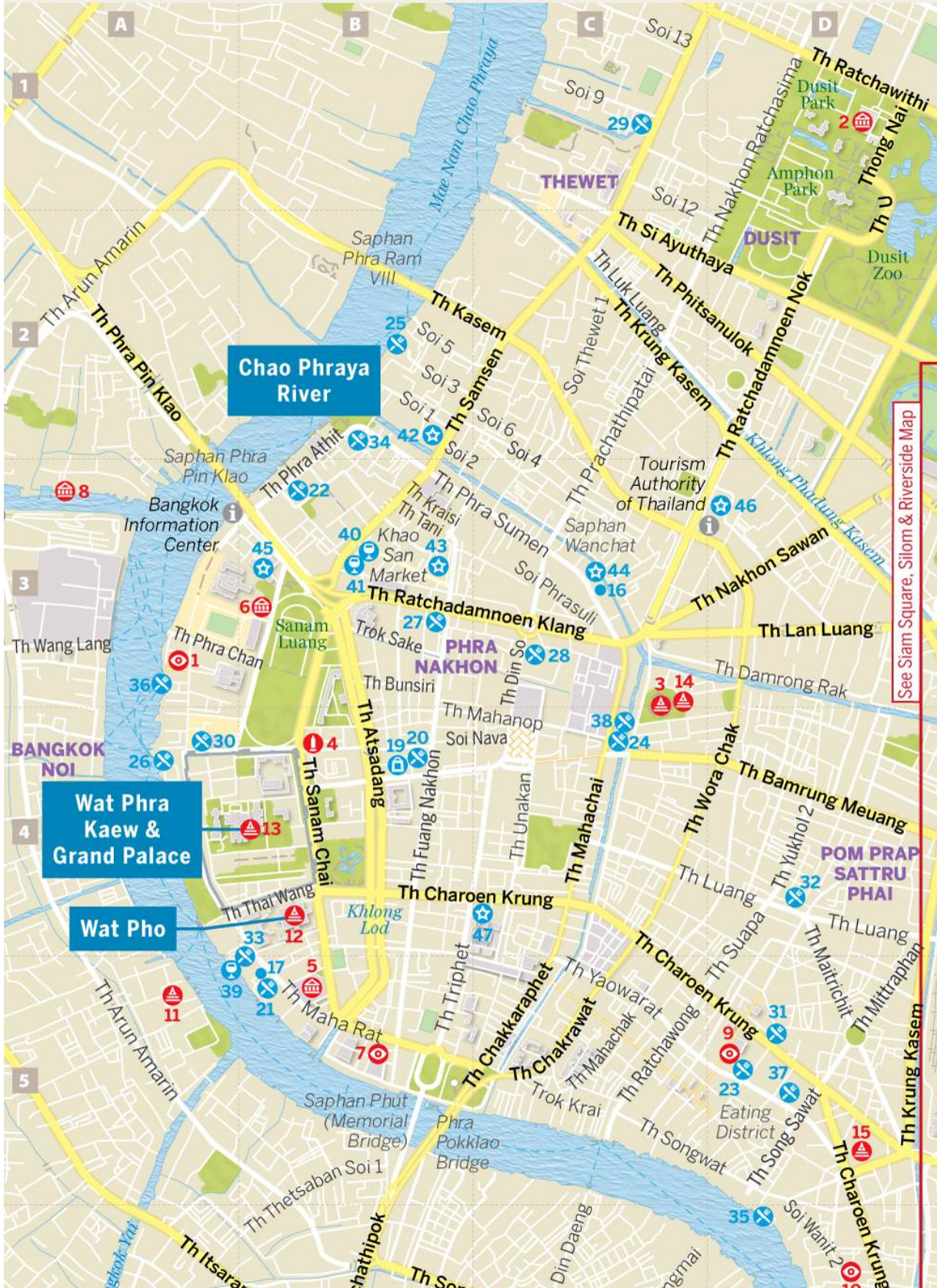
1 Start with the city's most famous attraction, the architecturally flamboyant and domestically revered **Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace**.

2 Head to the shady and peaceful **Wat Pho** temple where you can enjoy a traditional healing massage.

0 0.4 miles 800 m

Ko Ratanakosin, Banglamphu & Chinatown

0 500 m
0 0.25 miles



See Siam Square, Silom & Riverside Map



Ko Ratanakosin, Banglamphu & Chinatown

 Sights

- | | | |
|----|--|----------|
| 1 | Amulet Market | A3 |
| 2 | Dusit Palace Park | D1 |
| 3 | Golden Mount | C3 |
| 4 | Lak Meuang | B4 |
| 5 | Museum of Siam | B5 |
| 6 | National Museum | B3 |
| 7 | Pak Khlong Talat | B5 |
| | Phra Buddha Maha Suwanna Patimakorn Exhibition | (see 15) |
| 8 | Royal Barges National Museum | A3 |
| 9 | Talat Mai | D5 |
| 10 | Talat Noi | D6 |
| 11 | Wat Arun | A5 |
| 12 | Wat Pho | B4 |
| 13 | Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace | B4 |
| 14 | Wat Saket | C3 |
| 15 | Wat Traimit \ (Golden Buddha) \ | D5 |
| | Yaowarat Chinatown Heritage Center | (see 15) |

Activities, Courses & Tours

- | | | |
|----|---|----------|
| 16 | Bangkok Bold Cooking Studio | C3 |
| 17 | Chetawan Traditional Massage School | B5 |
| 18 | Co van Kessel Bangkok Tours | D6 |
| | Massage Pavilions | (see 12) |
| | National Museum Tours | (see 6) |

Shopping

- ## 19 Heritage Craft

Eating

20	Chote Chitr	B4
21	Err	B5
22	Hemlock	B3
23	Hoon Kuang	D5
24	Jay Fai	C4
25	Khinlom Chom Sa-Phan	B2
	Khun Yah Cuisine	(see 15)
26	Khunkung	A4
27	Kimleng	B3
28	Krua Apsorn	C3
29	Krua Apsorn	C1
30	Ming Lee	A4
31	Nai Mong Hoi Thod	D5
32	Nay Hong	D4
33	Pa Aew	B5
34	Roti-Mataba	B2
35	Samsara	D6
36	Savoey	A3
37	Thanon Phadungdao Seafood Stalls	D5
38	Thip Samai	C4

Drinking & Nightlife

39	Amorosa	A5
40	Hippie de Bar	B3
41	The Bank	B3

Entertainment

42	Ad Here the 13th	B2
43	Brick Bar	B3
44	Brown Sugar	C3
45	National Theatre	B3
46	Ratchadamnoen Stadium	D3
47	Sala Chalerkrung	C4

Information

	Office of the National Museum	(see 6)
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SIGHTS

Ko Ratanakosin & Banglamphu

Amulet Market

Market

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(ตลาดพระเครื่องวัดมหาธาตุ; Th Maha Rat; 🕒 7am-5pm; **FREE** Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) This arcane and fascinating market claims both the footpaths along Th Maha Rat and Th Phra Chan, as well as a dense network of covered market stalls that run south from Phra Chan Pier; the easiest entry point is clearly marked Trok Maha That. The trade is based around small talismans carefully prized by collectors, monks, taxi drivers and people in dangerous professions.

Potential buyers, often already sporting many amulets, can be seen bargaining and flipping through magazines dedicated to the amulets, some of which command astronomical prices. It's a great place to just wander and watch men (because it's rarely women) looking through magnifying glasses at the tiny amulets, seeking hidden meaning and, if they're lucky, hidden value.



AMULET MARKET / DAVID C PHILLIPS/GETTY IMAGES ©

National Museum

Museum

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(พิพิธภัณฑ์สถานแห่งชาติ; 4 Th Na Phra That; admission 200B; 🕒 9am-4pm Wed-Sun; [FREE](#) Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) Often touted as Southeast Asia's biggest museum, Thailand's National Museum is home to an impressive, albeit occasionally dusty, collection of items, best appreciated on one of the museum's twice-weekly **guided tours** (free with museum admission; 🕒 9.30am Wed & Thu).

Most of the museum's structures were built in 1782 as the palace of Rama I's viceroy, Prince Wang Na. Rama V turned it into a museum in 1874, and today there are three permanent exhibitions spread out over several buildings. At the time of research some of the exhibition halls were being renovated.

Lak Meuang

Monument

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(ศาลหลักเมือง; cnr Th Sanam Chai & Th Lak Meuang; 🕒 6.30am-6.30pm; **FREE** Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) Serving as the spiritual keystone of Bangkok, Lak Meuang is a phallus-shaped wooden pillar erected by Rama I during the foundation of the city in 1782. Part of an animistic tradition, the city pillar embodies the city's guardian spirit (Phra Sayam Thewathirat) and also lends a practical purpose as a marker of a town's crossroads and measuring point for distances between towns.

If you're lucky, *lá·kon gâa bon* (a commissioned dance) may be in progress. Brilliantly costumed dancers measure out subtle movements as gratitude to the guardian spirit for granting a worshipper's wish.

Museum of Siam

Museum

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(สถาบันพิพิธภัณฑ์การเรียนรู้แห่งชาติ; www.museumsiam.org; Th Maha Rat; admission 300B; 🕒 10am-6pm Tue-Sun; 🕒; **FREE** Tien Pier) This fun museum employs a variety of media to explore the origins of the Thai people and their culture. Housed in a European-style 19th-century building that was once the Ministry of Commerce, the exhibits are presented in a contemporary, engaging and interactive fashion not typically found in Thailand's museums. They are also refreshingly balanced and entertaining, with galleries dealing with a range of questions about the origins of the nation and its people.

Golden Mount & Wat Saket

Buddhist Temple

FREE **Golden Mount** **MAP** **GOOGLE MAP** (ภูเขาทอง, Phu Khao Thong; **MAP**; off Th Boriphat; admission to summit of Golden Mount 10B;

🕒 7.30am-5.30pm; **FREE** klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) was commissioned by Rama III, who ordered that the earth dug out to create Bangkok's expanding *klong* network be piled up to build an enormous, 100m-high, 500m-wide *chedi*.

Next door, seemingly peaceful **Wat Saket** **MAP** **GOOGLE MAP** (วัดสระเกศ; **MAP**; off Th Boriphat; **FREE** klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) **FREE** contains murals that are among both the most beautiful and the

goriest in the country; proceed to the pillar behind the Buddha statue for explicit depictions of Buddhist hell.

In November there's a festival in the grounds that includes an enchanting candlelight procession up the Golden Mount.



VISITORS TO A TEMPLE IN CHINATOWN / FRANK CARTER/GETTY IMAGES ©

Dress for the Occasion

Many of Bangkok's biggest tourist attractions are sacred places, and visitors should dress and behave appropriately. In particular, you won't be allowed to enter Wat Phra Kaew & Grand Palace and Dusit Palace Park unless you're well covered. Shorts, sleeveless shirts, spaghetti-strap tops, short skirts, cropped pants – basically anything that doesn't cover to your elbows or ankles – are not allowed. Expect to be shown into a dressing room and loaned a sarong before entry if you don't comply.

Chinatown

Wat Traimit (Golden Buddha)

Buddhist Temple

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(วัดไตรมิตร, Temple of the Golden Buddha; Th Mittaphap Thai-China; admission 40B; 🕒 8am-5pm; [FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1) The attraction at Wat Traimit is undoubtedly the impressive 3m-tall, 5.5-tonne, **solid-gold Buddha image**, which gleams like, well, gold. Sculpted in the graceful Sukhothai style, the image was 'discovered' some 40 years ago beneath a stucco/plaster exterior, when it fell from a crane while being moved to a new building within the temple compound.

The 2nd floor of the building is home to the **Phra Buddha Maha Suwanna Patimakorn Exhibition** (admission 100B; 🕒 8am-4pm Tue-Sun), which has exhibits on how the statue was made, discovered and came to arrive at its current home, while the 3rd floor is home to the **Yaowarat Chinatown Heritage Center** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (admission 100B; 🕒 8am-4pm Tue-Sun), a small but engaging museum with multimedia exhibits on the history of Bangkok's Chinatown and its residents.

Talat Mai

Market

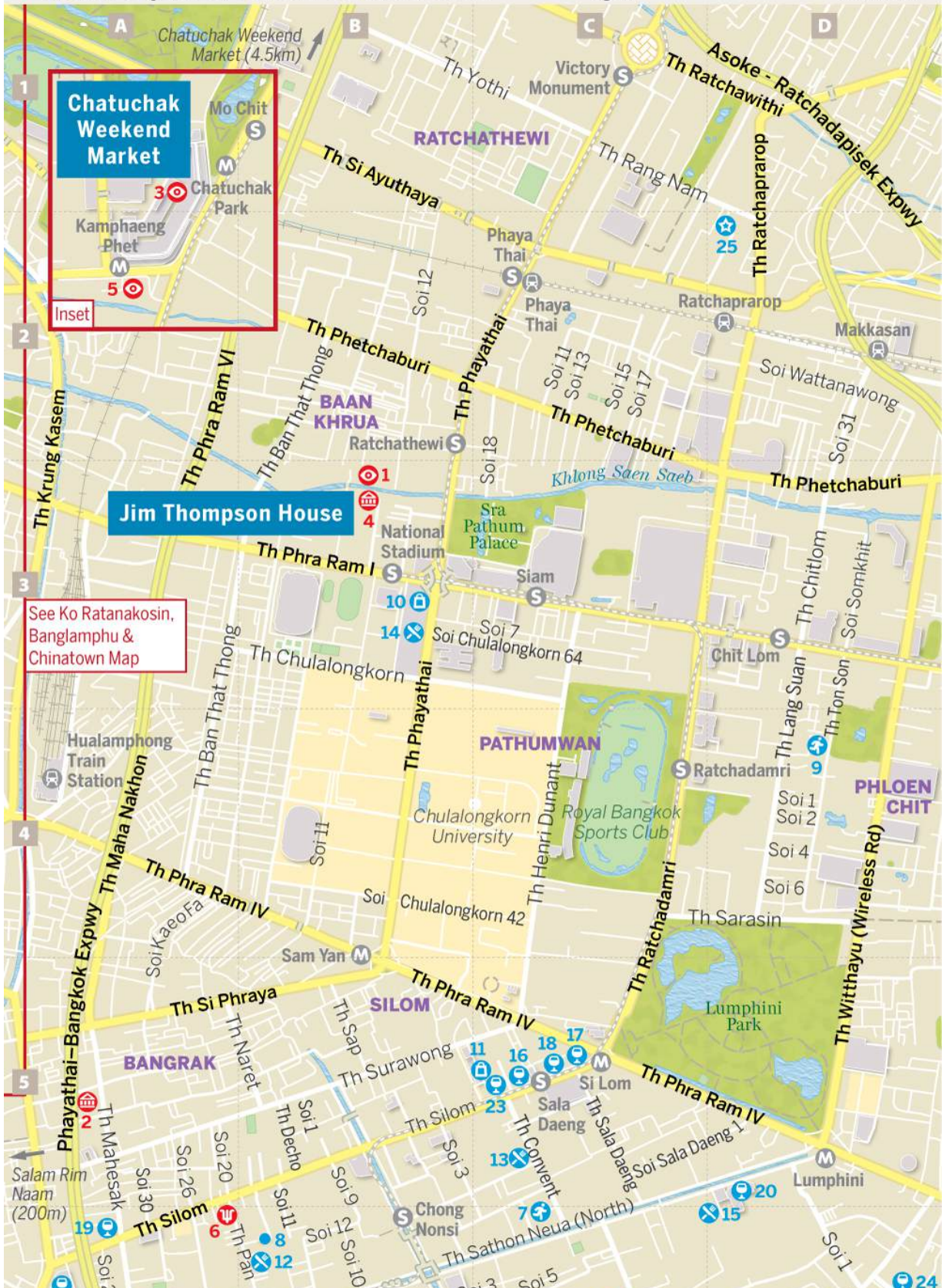
[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(ตลาดใหม่; Soi Yaowarat 6/Charoen Krung 16; 🕒 6am-6pm; [FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) With nearly two centuries of commerce under its belt, New Market is no longer an entirely accurate name for this strip of commerce. Regardless, this is Bangkok's, if not Thailand's, most Chinese market, and the dried goods, seasonings, spices and sauces will be familiar to anyone who's ever spent time in China. Even if you're not interested in food, the hectic atmosphere (be on guard for motorcycles squeezing between shoppers) and exotic sights and smells culminate in something of a surreal sensory experience.

While much of the market centres on cooking ingredients, the section north of Th Charoen Krung (equivalent to Soi 21, Th

Charoen Krung) is known for selling incense, paper effigies and ceremonial sweets – the essential elements of a traditional Chinese funeral.

0 1 km
0 0.5 miles





Siam Square, Silom & Riverside

Sights

	Aood Bankruea Thai Silk	(see 1)
1	Baan Khrua	B3
2	Bangkokian Museum	A5
3	Chatuchak Weekend Market	A1
4	Jim Thompson House	B3
5	Or Tor Kor Market	A2
	Phamai Baan Krua	(see 1)
6	Sri Mariamman Temple	A6

Activities, Courses & Tours

7	Ruen-Nuad Massage Studio	C6
8	Silom Thai Cooking School	B6
9	Spa 1930	D4

Shopping

10	MBK Center	B3
11	Patpong Night Market	C5

Eating

12	Chennai Kitchen	B6
13	Eat Me	C5
14	MBK Food Island	B3
15	nahm	D6

Drinking & Nightlife

16	Balcony	C5
17	DJ Station	C5
18	G Bangkok	C5
19	Maggie Choo's	A6
20	Moon Bar	D5

21 Sky Bar	A6
22 Smalls	C6
23 Telephone Pub	C5
24 Wong's Place	D6
★ Entertainment	
25 Raintree	D2

Pak Khlong Talat

Market

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(ปากคลองตลาด, Flower Market; Th Chakkaraphet; 🕒 24hr; **FREE** Pak Klong Talad Pier, Saphan Phut/Memorial Bridge Pier) This sprawling wholesale flower market has become a tourist attraction in its own right. The endless piles of delicate orchids, rows of roses and stacks of button carnations are a sight to be seen, and the shirtless porters wheeling blazing piles of colour set the place in motion. The best time to come is late at night, when the goods arrive from upcountry.

During the daytime, Pak Khlong Talat is one of the city's largest wholesale vegetable markets.

👁 Silom & Riverside

Sri Mariamman Temple

Hindu Temple

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(วัดพระศรีมหาอุมาเทวี/วัดแขก, Wat Phra Si Maha Umathewi; cnr Th Silom & Th Pan; 🕒 6am-8pm; **S** Surasak exit 3) **FREE** Arrestingly flamboyant, the Sri Mariamman Hindu temple is a wild collision of colours, shapes and deities. It was built in the 1860s by Tamil immigrants and features a 6m facade of intertwined, full-colour Hindu deities. While most of the people working in the temple hail from the Indian subcontinent, you will likely see plenty of Thai and Chinese devotees praying here as well. This is because the Hindu gods figure just as prominently in their individualistic approach to religion.

Bangkokian Museum

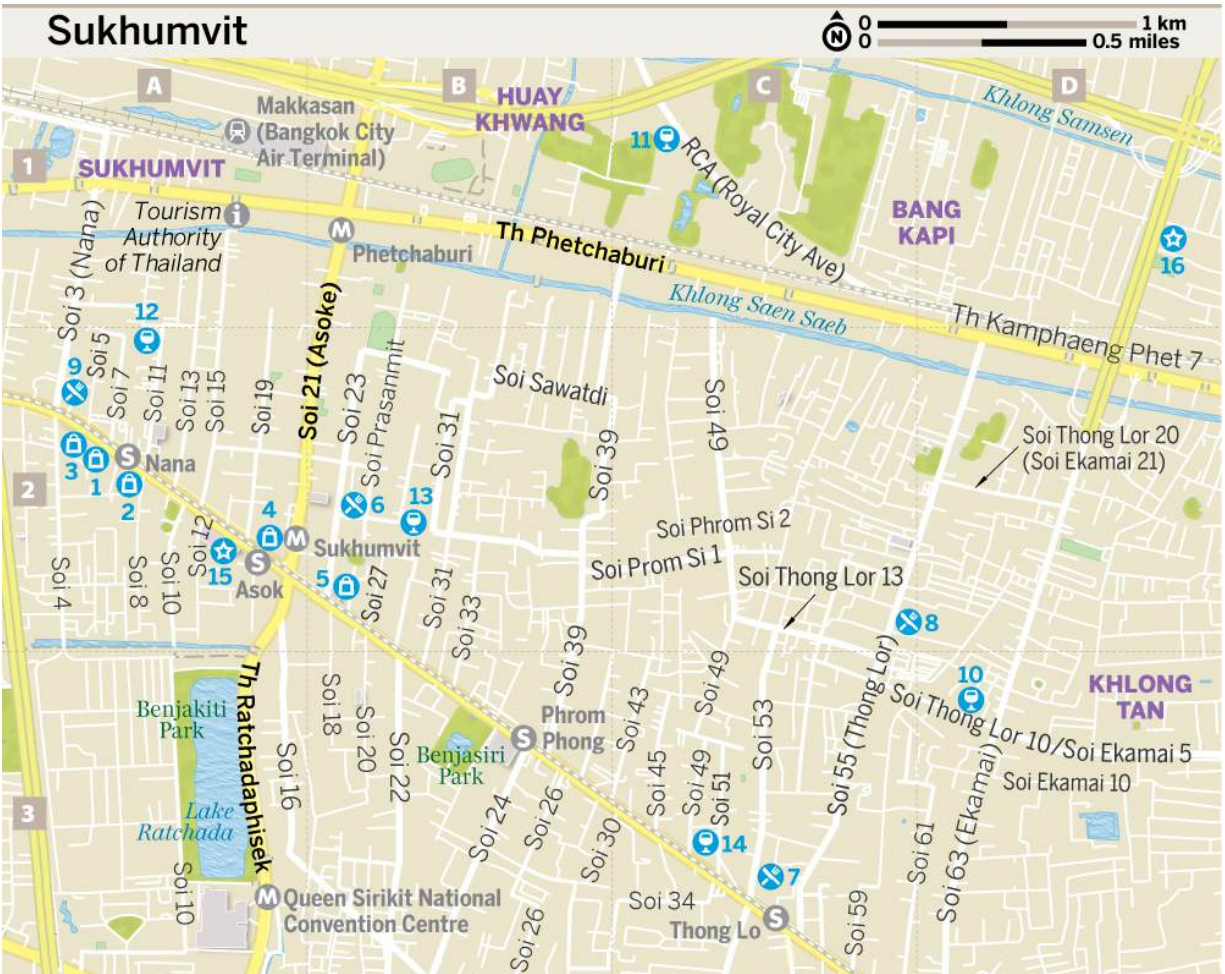
Museum

MAP [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(พิพิธภัณฑ์ชาวบางกอก; 273 Soi 43, Th Charoen Krung; admission by donation; 🕒 10am-4pm Wed-Sun; **FREE** Si Phraya/River City Pier) A collection of three antique structures built during the early 20th century, the Bangkokian Museum illustrates an often-overlooked period of Bangkok's history.

The main building was built in 1937 as a home for the Surawadee family and, as the signs inform us, was finished by Chinese carpenters on time and for less than the budgeted 2400B (which would barely buy a door handle today). This building and the large wooden one to the right, which was added as a boarding house to help cover costs, are filled with the detritus of postwar family life and offer a fascinating window into the period.

The third building, at the back of the block, was built in 1929 as a surgery for a British doctor, though he died soon after arriving in Thailand.



Sukhumvit

Shopping

1	Nickermann's	A2
2	Raja's Fashions	A2
3	Rajawongse	A2
	Ricky's Fashion House	(see 9)
4	Terminal 21	A2
5	ThaiCraft Fair	B2

Eating

6	Bharani	B2
7	Bo\lan	C3
8	Boon Tong Kiat Singapore Chicken Rice	C2

9 Nasir Al-Masri	A2
🍷 Drinking & Nightlife	
10 Arena 10	D3
11 Castro	C1
12 Levels	A2
13 Narz	B2
14 WTF	C3
🌟 Entertainment	
15 Living Room	A2
16 Parking Toys' Watt	D1

ACTIVITIES

Ruen-Nuad Massage Studio

Massage

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(📞 02 632 2662; 42 Th Convent; massage per hr 350B; 🕒 10am-9pm; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 2) Set in a refurbished wooden house, this charming place successfully avoids both the tackiness and New Agedness that characterise most Bangkok Thai-massage joints. Prices are reasonable, too.

Massage Pavilions

Massage

(**MAP**; Wat Pho, Th Sanam Chai; Thai massage per hr 420B; 🕒 9am-6pm; **FREE** Tien Pier) These two air-conditioned *săh-lah* (pavilions) located near the eastern entrance to the Wat Pho grounds are run by the **massage school** (**MAP**; 📞 02 622 3551; www.watpomassage.com; 392/32-33 Soi Phen Phat; lessons from 2500B, Thai massage per hour 420B; 🕒 lessons 9am-4pm, massage 9am-6pm; **FREE** Tien Pier) affiliated with Wat Pho, which is the country's primary training centre for Thai traditional massage. The menu is short but the quality is guaranteed, and after a day of temple sightseeing it's hard to think of a better way to cool down and chill out.

Spa 1930

Spa

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(📞 02 254 8606; www.spa1930.com; 42 Th Ton Son; Thai massage from 1000B, spa packages from 3500B; 🕒 9.30am-9.30pm; 📍 Chit Lom exit 4) Discreet and sophisticated, Spa 1930 rescues relaxers from the contrived spa ambience of New Age music and ingredients you'd rather see at a dinner party. The menu is simple (face, body care and body massage) and the scrubs and massage oils are logical players.

TOURS

Although the pollution and heat are significant obstacles, Bangkok is a fascinating city to explore on foot. If you'd rather do it with an expert guide, **Bangkok Private Tours** (www.bangkokprivatetours.com; tours from US\$150) and **Co van Kessel Bangkok Tours** **MAP**

GOOGLE MAP (📞 02 639 7351; www.covankessel.com; ground fl, River City, 23 Th Yotha; tours from 950B; 🕒 6am-7pm; **FREE** River City Pier) conduct themed walking tours of the city. Foodies will appreciate the offerings at **Bangkok Food Tours** (📞 095 943 9222; www.bangkokfoodtours.com; tours from 1150B) or **Chili Paste Tours** (📞 085 143 6779, 094 552 2361; www.foodtoursbangkok.com; tours from 1800B), both of which offer half-day culinary tours of Bangkok's older neighbourhoods.

SHOPPING

MBK Center

Shopping Centre

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(www.mbk-center.com; cnr Th Phra Ram I & Th Phayathai; 🕒 10am-10pm; 📍 National Stadium exit 4) This colossal shopping mall underwent an extensive renovation in 2015 and is set to retain its role as one of Bangkok's top attractions. On any given weekend half of Bangkok's residents (and most of its tourists) can be found here combing

through a seemingly inexhaustible range of small stalls and shops that span a whopping eight floors.

MBK is Bangkok's cheapest place to buy mobile phones and accessories (4th floor). It's also one of the better places to stock up on camera gear (ground floor and 5th floor), and the expansive food court (6th floor) is one of the best in town.

Terminal 21

Shopping Centre

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(www.terminal21.co.th; cnr Th Sukhumvit & Soi 21/Asoke; 🕒 10am-10pm; **M** Sukhumvit exit 3, **S** Asok exit 3) Seemingly catering to a Thai need for wacky objects to be photographed in front of, this new mall is worth a visit for the spectacle as much as the shopping. Start at the basement-level 'airport' and proceed upwards through 'Paris', 'Tokyo' and other city-themed floors. Who knows, you might even buy something.

Asiatique

Market

(www.thaiasiatique.com; Soi 72-76, Th Charoen Krung; 🕒 4-11pm; **FREE** shuttle boat from Sathon/Central Pier) One of Bangkok's more popular night markets, Asiatique takes the form of warehouses of commerce next to Mae Nam Chao Phraya. Expect clothing, handicrafts, souvenirs and quite a few dining and drinking venues.

To get here, take one of the frequent, free shuttle boats from Sathon/Central Pier that run from 4pm to 11.30pm.

Patpong Night Market

Souvenirs

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(Th Phat Phong & Soi Phat Phong 2; 🕒 6pm-midnight; **M** Si Lom exit 2, **S** Sala Daeng exit 1) You'll be faced with the competing distractions of strip-clubbing and shopping in this infamous area. And true to the area's illicit leanings, pirated goods (in particular watches) make a prominent appearance even amid a wholesome crowd of families and straight-laced couples. Bargain with determination, as first-quoted prices tend to be astronomically high.



VIMANMEK TEAK MANSION / LONELY PLANET/GETTY IMAGES ©

Dusit Palace Park

Following his first European tour in 1897, Rama V (King Chulalongkorn; r 1868–1910) returned with visions of European castles and set about transforming these styles into a uniquely Thai expression, today's **Dusit Palace Park** (วังสวนดุสิต; [MAP](#); bounded by Th Ratchawithi, Th U Thong Nai & Th Nakhon Ratchasima; admission adult/child 100/20B, or free with Grand Palace ticket; 🕒 9.30am-4pm Tue-Sun; [FREE](#) Thewet Pier, [S](#) Phaya Thai exit 2 & taxi).

The premier attraction is the Vimanmek Teak Mansion, which was originally constructed on Ko Si Chang in 1868 and moved to the present site in 1910. It contains 81 rooms, halls and anterooms, and is said to be the world's largest golden-teak building, allegedly built without the use of a single nail. The mansion was the first permanent building on the Dusit Palace grounds, and served as Rama V's residence in the early 1900s.

The interior of the mansion contains various personal effects of the king and a treasure trove of early Ratanakosin-era art objects and antiques.

Compulsory tours (in English) leave every 30 minutes between 9.45am and 3.15pm, and last about an hour. Because this is royal property, visitors should wear shirts with sleeves and long pants (no cropped pants) or long skirts.

Heritage Craft

Handicrafts

MAP GOOGLE MAP

(35 Th Bamrung Meuang; 🕒 11am-6pm Mon-Fri; 🆓 klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) Handicrafts with a conscience: this new boutique is an atmospheric showcase for the quality domestic wares of **ThaiCraft** (www.thaicraft.org; L fl, Jasmine City Bldg, cnr Soi 23 & Th Sukhumvit; 🕒 10am-3pm; 🚇 Sukhumvit exit 2, 🚇 Asok exit 3), some of which are produced via fair trade practices. Items include silks from Thailand's northeast, baskets from the south and jewellery from the north, and there's also an inviting on-site cafe.

🌟 ENTERTAINMENT

Ratchadamnoen Stadium

Spectator Sport

MAP GOOGLE MAP

(off Th Ratchadamnoen Nok; tickets 3rd-class/2nd-class/ringside 1000/1500/2000B; 🆓 Thewet Pier, 🚇 Phaya Thai exit 3 & taxi)

Ratchadamnoen Stadium, Bangkok's oldest and most venerable venue for *moo·ay tai* (Thai boxing; also spelt *muay thai*), hosts matches on Monday, Wednesday and Thursday from 6.30pm to around 11pm, and Sunday at 3pm and 6.30pm. Be sure to buy tickets from the official ticket counter, not from the touts and scalpers who hang around outside the entrance.

Lumpinee Boxing Stadium

Spectator Sport

(📞 02 282 3141; www.muaythailumpinee.net/en; 6 Th Ramintra; tickets 3rd-class/2nd-class/ringside 1000/1500/2000B; 🚇 Chatuchak Park exit 2 &

taxi, [S](#) Mo Chit exit 3 & taxi) The other of Bangkok's two premier Thai boxing rings has moved to fancy new digs north of town. Matches occur on Tuesdays and Fridays from 6.30pm to 11pm, and on Saturdays at 4pm to 8.30pm and from 9pm to 12.30am. At time of research there were plans underway for a Thai boxing museum and a school for foreign fighters.

It's located well north of central Bangkok; the best way to get here is via taxi from BTS Mo Chit or MRT Chatuchak Park.



DANCERS PERFORMING AT SALA RIM NAAM / PETER STUCKINGS/GETTY IMAGES ©

National Theatre

Theatre

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(☎ 02 224 1342; 2 Th Ratchini; tickets 60-100B; [FREE](#) Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) The National Theatre holds performances of *kŏhn* (masked dance-drama based on stories from the *Ramakian*) at 2pm on the first and second Sundays of the month from January to September, and *lá·kon* (Thai dance-dramas) at 2pm on the first

and second Sundays of the month from October to December. Tickets go on sale an hour before performances begin.

Sala Rim Naam

Theatre

(☎ 02 437 3080; www.mandarinoriental.com/bangkok/fine-dining/sala-rim-naam; Mandarin Oriental Hotel, Soi 40/Oriental, Th Charoen Krung; tickets adult/child 1999/1700B; 🕒 dinner & show 8.15-9.30pm; 🆓 Oriental Pier or hotel shuttle boat from Sathon/Central Pier) The historic Mandarin Oriental hosts dinner theatre in a sumptuous Thai pavilion located across the river in Thonburi. The price is well above the average, reflecting the means of the hotel's client base, but the performance gets positive reviews.

Sala Chalermkrung

Theatre

MAP GOOGLE MAP

(☎ 02 222 0434; www.salachalermkrung.com; 66 Th Charoen Krung; tickets 800-1200B; 🕒 shows 7.30pm Thu & Fri; 🆓 Saphan Phut/Memorial Bridge Pier, 📍 Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) This Art Deco Bangkok landmark, a former cinema dating to 1933, is one of the few remaining places *kōhn* can be witnessed. The traditional Thai dance-drama is enhanced here by laser graphics, high-tech audio and English subtitles. Concerts and other events are also held; check the website for details.

EATING

Ko Ratanakosin & Banglamphu

Ming Lee

Chinese-Thai \$

MAP GOOGLE MAP

(28-30 Th Na Phra Lan, no roman-script sign; mains 70-100B; 🕒 11.30am-6pm; 🆓 Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) Hidden in plain sight across from Wat Phra Kaew is this decades-old shophouse restaurant. The menu spans Western/Chinese dishes (stewed tongue, for example) and Thai standards (such as the impossibly

tart and garlicky ‘beef spicy salad’). Often closed before 6pm, Ming Lee is best approached as a post-sightseeing lunch option.

There’s no English-language sign here; look for the last shophouse before Silpakorn University.

Pa Aew

Central Thai \$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(Th Maha Rat, no roman-script sign; mains 20-60B; 🕒 10am-5pm Tue-Sat; [FREE](#) Tien Pier) Pull up a plastic stool for some rich, seafood-heavy, Bangkok-style fare. It’s a bare-bones, open-air curry stall, but for taste, Pa Aew is one of our favourite places to eat in this part of town.

There’s no English-language sign; look for the exposed trays of food directly in front of the Krung Thai Bank near the corner with Soi Pratu Nokying.

Kimleng

Thai \$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(158-160 Th Tanao; mains 60-150B; 🕒 10am-10pm Mon-Sat; ❄️; [FREE](#) klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) This tiny family-run restaurant specialises in the dishes and flavours of central Thailand. It’s a good place to dip your toes in the local cuisine via an authentic *yam* (Thai-style salad), such as *yam plah dùk foo*, a mixture of catfish deep-fried until crispy and strands of tart, green mango.

Savoey

Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(www.savoey.co.th; 1st fl, Maharaj Pier, Th Maha Rat; mains 125-1800B; 🕒 10am-10pm; ❄️; [FREE](#) Maharaj Pier, Chang Pier) A chain with other branches across town, you’re not going to find heaps of character here, but you will get consistency, river views, air-con, and a seafood-heavy menu that should appeal to just about everybody. Come cool evenings, take advantage of the open-air, riverside deck.

Hemlock

Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(56 Th Phra Athit; mains 75-280B; 🕒 4pm-midnight Mon-Sat; ❄️🌶️; **FREE** Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) Taking full advantage of its cosy shophouse location, this perennial favourite has enough style to feel like a special night out, but doesn't skimp on flavour or preparation. And unlike at other similar places, the eclectic menu here reads like an ancient literary work, reviving old dishes from aristocratic kitchens across the country, not to mention several meat-free items.



THAI STREET FOOD / DAN BANNISTER/GETTY IMAGES ©

Err

Thai \$\$

MAP **GOOGLE MAP**

(www.errbkk.com; off Th Maha Rat; dishes 65-360B; 🕒 11am-late Tue-Sun; ❄️; **FREE** Tien Pier) Think of all those different smoky, spicy, crispy, meaty bites you've encountered on the street. Now imagine them assembled in one funky, retro-themed locale, and coupled with tasty Thai-themed cocktails and domestic microbrews. If Err (a

Thai colloquialism for agreement) seems too good to be true, we empathise, but insist that it's true.

Krua Apsorn

Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(www.kruaapsorn.com; Th Din So; mains 80-400B; 🕒 10.30am-8pm Mon-Sat; ❄️; **FREE** klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) This homely dining room is a favourite of members of the Thai royal family and restaurant critics alike. Just about all of the central and southern Thai dishes are tasty, but regulars never miss the chance to order the decadent stir-fried crab with yellow chilli or the *tortilla Española*-like omelette with crab.

There's another branch on Th Samsen in **Dusit** (www.kruaapsorn.com; 503-505 Th Samsen; mains 80-400B; 🕒 10.30am-7.30pm Mon-Fri, to 6pm Sat; ❄️; **FREE** Thewet Pier).

Khunkung

Central Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(Navy Club; 77 Th Maha Rat; mains 70-450B; 🕒 11am-2pm & 6-10pm Mon-Fri, 11am-10pm Sat & Sun; ❄️; **FREE** Chang Pier, Maharaj Pier, Phra Chan Tai Pier) The restaurant of the Royal Navy Association has one of the few coveted riverfront locations along this stretch of Mae Nam Chao Phraya. Locals come for the combination of views and cheap and tasty seafood-based eats – ostensibly not for the cafeteria-like atmosphere.

Khunkung is just off the main road; look for the sign on Th Maha Rat that says 'Navy Club'.



VEGETARIAN CURRY PUFF / JIRABU/GETTY IMAGES ©

Vegetarian Festival in Chinatown

During the annual Vegetarian Festival in September/October, Bangkok's Chinatown becomes a virtual orgy of nonmeat cuisine. The festivities centre on Chinatown's main street, Th Yaowarat, and the **Talat Noi** [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (ตลาดน้อย; off Th Charoen Krung; 🕒 7am-7pm; [FREE](#) Marine Department Pier) area, but food shops and stalls all over the city post yellow flags to announce their meat-free status.

Celebrating alongside the ethnic Chinese are Thais who look forward to the special dishes that appear during the festival period. Most restaurants put their normal menus on hold and instead prepare soy-based substitutes for standard Thai dishes like *đôm yam* (Thai-style spicy/sour soup) and *gaang kěe·o wăhn* (green curry). Even Thai regional cuisines are sold (without the meat, of course). Yellow Hokkien-style noodles often make an

appearance in the special festival dishes, usually in stir-frys along with meaty mushrooms and big hunks of vegetables.

Along with abstinence from meat, the 10-day festival is celebrated with special visits to the temple, often requiring worshippers to dress in white.

Jay Fai

Central Thai \$\$\$

MAP

GOOGLE MAP

(327 Th Mahachai; mains 180-1000B; 🕒 3pm-2am Mon-Sat; **FREE** klong boat to Phanfa Leelard Pier) You wouldn't think so by looking at her bare-bones dining room, but Jay Fai is known far and wide for serving Bangkok's most expensive *pàt kêe mow* ('drunkard's noodles'; wide rice noodles fried with seafood and Thai herbs).

Jay Fai is located in a virtually unmarked shophouse on Th Mahachai, directly across from a 7-Eleven.

The *pàt kêe mow* price is justified by the copious fresh seafood, as well as Jay Fai's distinct frying style that results in an almost oil-free finished product.



ALEXANDER SPATARI/GETTY IMAGES ©

The Sex Industry

Prostitution has been widespread in Thailand since long before the country became famous for it. Throughout Thai history the practice was tolerated though not respected.

Due to pressure from the UN, prostitution was declared illegal in 1960, though entertainment places (go-go bars, beer bars, massage parlours, karaoke bars and bathhouses) are governed by a separate law passed in 1966. These establishments are licensed and can legally provide nonsexual services (such as dancing, massage, a drinking buddy); sexual services occur through these venues but they are not technically the businesses' purpose.

With the arrival of the US military in Southeast Asia in the 1960s and '70s, enterprising forces adapted prostitution to suit foreigners, in turn creating an industry that persists today. Indeed, this foreigner-oriented sex industry is still a prominent part of Thailand's tourist economy.

In 1998 the International Labour Organization, a UN agency, advised Southeast Asian countries, including Thailand, to recognise prostitution as an economic sector and income generator. It is estimated that one third of the entertainment establishments are registered with the government and the majority pay an informal tax in the form of police bribes.



Chinatown

Khun Yah Cuisine

Central Thai \$

( **MAP**; off Th Mittaphap Thai-China, no roman-script sign; mains from 40B;

 6am-1.30pm Mon-Fri;  **FREE** Ratchawong Pier,  **M** Hua Lamphong exit 1)

Strategically located for a lunch break after visiting Wat Traimit (Golden Buddha), Khun Yah specialises in the full-flavoured curries, relishes, stir-fries and noodle dishes of central Thailand. But be sure to get here early; come noon many dishes are already sold out.

Khun Yah Cuisine has no English-language sign but is located just east of the Golden Buddha, in the same compound.



CHILLIES FOR SALE IN A CHINATOWN MARKET / JOHN DAKERS/GETTY IMAGES ©

Nay Hong

Chinese-Thai \$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(off Th Yukol 2, no roman-script sign; mains 35-50B; 🕒 4-10pm;

[FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) The reward for locating this hole-in-the-wall is one of the best fried noodle dishes in Bangkok. The dish in question is *gǎo·ay dǎe·o kôo·a gàì*, flat rice noodles fried with garlic oil, chicken and egg.

To find it, proceed north from the corner of Th Suapa and Th Luang, then turn right into the first side-street; it's at the end of the narrow alleyway.

Thanon Phadungdao Seafood Stalls

Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(cnr Th Phadungdao & Th Yaowarat; mains 100-600B; 🕒 4pm-midnight Tue-Sun; [FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) After sunset, these two opposing open-air restaurants – each of which claims to

be the original – become a culinary train wreck of outdoor barbecues, screaming staff, iced seafood trays and messy sidewalk seating. True, the vast majority of diners are foreign tourists, but this has little impact on the cheerful setting, the fun experience and the cheap bill.

Hoon Kuang

Chinese-Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(381 Th Yaowarat; mains 90-240B; 🕒 11am-7.45pm Mon-Sat; ❄️;

[FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) Serving the food of Chinatown's streets in air-con comfort is this low-key, long-standing staple. The must-eat dishes are pictured on the door, but it'd be a pity to miss the 'prawn curry flat rice noodle', a unique mash-up of two Chinese-Thai dishes – crab in curry powder and flash-fried noodles – that will make you wonder why they were ever served apart.

Samsara

Japanese, Thai \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(Soi Khang Wat Pathum Khongkha; mains 110-320B; 🕒 4pm-midnight Tue-Thu, to 1am Fri-Sun; 🍷; [FREE](#) Ratchawong Pier, [M](#) Hua Lamphong exit 1 & taxi) Combining Japanese and Thai dishes, Belgian beers and an artfully ramshackle atmosphere, Samsara is easily Chinatown's most eclectic place to eat. It's also very tasty, and the generous riverside breezes and views simply add to the package.

The restaurant is at the end of tiny Soi Khang Wat Pathum Khongkha, just west of the temple of the same name.



Silom & Riverside

Chennai Kitchen

Indian \$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(107/4 Th Pan; mains 70-150B; 🕒 10am-3pm & 6-9.30pm; ❄️🍷; [S](#) Surasak exit 3) This thimble-sized mom-and-pop restaurant puts out some of the best southern Indian vegetarian food in town. Yard-long *dosai*

(a crispy southern Indian bread) is always a good choice, but if you're feeling indecisive (or exceptionally famished) go for the banana-leaf *thali* (set meal) that seems to incorporate just about everything in the kitchen.

Eat Me

International \$\$\$

(📞 02 238 0931; www.eatmerestaurant.com; Soi Phiphat 2; mains 275-1400B; 🕒 3pm-1am; ❄️🍷;  Si Lom exit 2,  Sala Daeng exit 2) The dishes here, with descriptions like 'charred whitlof and mozzarella salad with preserved lemon and dry aged Cecina beef' may sound all over the map or perhaps somewhat pretentious, but they're actually just plain tasty. A casual-yet-sophisticated atmosphere, excellent cocktails, a handsome wine list, and some of the city's best desserts also make this one of our favourite places in Bangkok to dine.

nahm

Thai \$\$\$

(📞 02 625 3388; www.comohotels.com/metropolitanbangkok/dining/nahm; ground fl, Metropolitan Hotel, 27 Th Sathon Tai/South; set lunch 550-1500B, set dinner 2300B, dishes 280-750B; 🕒 noon-2pm Mon-Fri, 7-10.30pm daily; ❄️;  Lumphini exit 2) Australian chef-author David Thompson is the man behind one of Bangkok's – and if you believe the critics, the world's – best Thai restaurants. Using ancient cookbooks as his inspiration, Thompson has given new life to previously extinct dishes with exotic descriptions such as 'smoked fish curry with prawns, chicken livers, cockles, chillies and black pepper'.

Dinner is best approached via the multicourse set meal, while lunch means *kà-nǒm jeen*, thin rice noodles served with curries.

If you're expecting bland, gentrified Thai food meant for foreigners, prepare to be disappointed. Reservations recommended.



Sukhumvit

Nasir Al-Masri

Middle Eastern \$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(4/6 Soi 3/1, Th Sukhumvit; mains 160-370B; 🕒 24hr; ❄️🍴; 📍 Nana exit 1)

One of several Middle Eastern restaurants on Soi 3/1, Nasir Al-Masri is easily recognisable by its floor-to-ceiling stainless steel 'theme'. Middle Eastern food often means meat, meat and more meat, but the menu here also includes several delicious veggie-based *mezze* (small dishes).

Bo.lan

Thai \$\$\$

[MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#)

(📞 02 260 2962; www.bolan.co.th; 24 Soi 53, Th Sukhumvit; set meals 980-2680B; 🕒 noon-2.30pm & 7-10.30pm Thu-Sun, 11.30am-10.30pm Tue & Wed;

❄️🍴; 📍 Thong Lo exit 1) Upscale Thai is often more garnish than flavour, but Bo.lan has proven to be the exception. Bo and Dylan (Bo.lan is a play on words that also means 'ancient') take a scholarly approach to Thai cuisine, and generous set meals featuring full-flavoured Thai dishes are the results of this tuition (à la carte is not available; meat-free meals are). Reservations recommended.



BANGKOK CITYSCAPE / 9ATTH/GETTY IMAGES ©

DRINKING & NIGHTLIFE

See Bangkok Nightlife Top Experience for bar and club information.

INFORMATION

Bangkok has two organisations that handle tourism matters: the Tourism Authority of Thailand (TAT) for countrywide information, and Bangkok Information Center for city-specific information. Also be aware that travel agents in the train station and near tourist centres co-opt 'T.A.T.' and 'Information' as part of their name to lure in commissions. These places are not officially sanctioned information services, but just agencies registered with the TAT.

Bangkok Information Center ( 02 225 7612-4; www.bangkoktourist.com; 17/1 Th Phra Athit;  9am-7pm Mon-Fri, to 5pm Sat & Sun;  Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier) City-specific tourism office providing maps, brochures and directions. Kiosks and booths are found around town; look for the green-on-white symbol of a mahout on an elephant.

Tourism Authority of Thailand Head office (TAT;  02 250 5500, call centre 1672; www.tourismthailand.org; 1600 Th Phetchaburi Tat Mai;  8.30am-4.30pm;  Phetchaburi exit 2); **Banglamphu** (TAT;  02 283 1500, call centre 1672; cnr Th Ratchadamnoen Nok & Th Chakraphatdi Phong;  8.30am-4.30pm;  klong boat Phanfa Leelard Pier); **Suvarnabhumi International Airport** (TAT;  02 134 0040, call centre 1672; www.tourismthailand.org; 2nd fl, btwn Gates 2 & 5, Suvarnabhumi International Airport;  24hr).



GOLD JEWELLERY FOR SALE / ZHYKOVA/GETTY IMAGES ©

Bangkok Street Smarts

Keep the following in mind to survive the traffic and avoid joining the list of tourists sucked in by Bangkok's numerous scam artists:

- Ignore 'helpful,' often well-dressed, English-speaking locals who tell you that tourist attractions and public transport are closed for a holiday or cleaning; it's the beginning of a con, most likely a gem scam.
- Skip the 50B túk-túk ride unless you have the time and willpower to resist a heavy sales pitch in a tailor or gem store.
- Good jewellery, gems and tailor shops aren't found through a túk-túk driver.
- Don't expect any pedestrian rights; put a Bangkokian between you and any oncoming traffic, and yield to anything with more metal than you.

- Walk away from the tourist strip to hail a taxi that will actually use the meter. Tell the driver 'meter.' If the driver refuses to put the meter on, get out.

GETTING THERE & AWAY

AIR

Suvarnabhumi International Airport The Airport Rail Link runs from Phaya Thai station to Suvarnabhumi (45B, 30 minutes, from 6am to midnight). Meter taxis run 24 hours and cost approximately 200B to 300B plus 50B airport surcharge and optional expressway tolls.

Don Mueang International Airport There are two bus lines from Bangkok's de facto budget airport: bus A1 makes stops at BTS Mo Chit (30B, frequent from 7.30am to 11.30pm), while bus A2 makes stops at BTS Mo Chit and BTS Victory Monument (30B, half-hourly from 7.30am to 11.30pm). Meter taxis from Don Mueang also charge an airport surcharge (50B); trips to town start at approximately 200B.

BUS

Eastern Bus Terminal ( 02 391 2504; Soi 40, Th Sukhumvit;  Ekkamai exit 2) The departure point for buses to points east, except for the border crossing at Aranya Prathet. Most people call it *sà-tǎh-nee èk-gà-mai* (Ekamai station). Accessible via Ekkamai BTS station.

Southern Bus Terminal (Sai Tai Mai;  02 422 4444, call centre 1490; Th Boromaratchachonanee) The departure point to all points south of Bangkok as well as western Thailand. It is commonly called *sǎi dâi mài*. A taxi to central Bangkok costs 120B.

Northern & Northeastern Bus Terminal (Mo Chit;  northeastern routes 02 936 2852, ext 602/605, northern routes 02 936 2841, ext 325/614; Th Kamphaeng Phet;  Kamphaeng Phet exit 1 & taxi,  Mo Chit exit 3 & taxi) North of Chatuchak Park, this hectic bus station is commonly

called *kõn sòng mǎo chít* (Mo Chit station) – not to be confused with Mo Chit BTS station. Buses depart for all northern and northeastern destinations, as well as some international destinations. It is a short taxi or motorcycle ride from Mo Chit BTS station or Chatuchak Park MRT station.

TRAIN

Hualamphong (☎ 02 220 4334, call centre 1690; www.railway.co.th; off Th Phra Ram IV; 🚉 Hua Lamphong exit 2) is the city's main train terminus. It's advisable to ignore all touts here and avoid the travel agencies. Call or check the website to get destination timetable and price information. The station is connected to the MRT.

GETTING AROUND

Bangkok may seem impenetrable at first, but its transport system is gradually improving. Taxis are the most expedient choice – although it's important to note that Bangkok traffic is nothing if not unpredictable. During rush hour, opt for public transport.

BTS & MRT

The elevated **BTS** ( 02 617 6000, tourist information 02 617 7341; www.bts.co.th), also known as the Skytrain (*rót fai fáa*), whisks you through 'new' Bangkok (Silom, Sukhumvit and Siam Sq). The interchange between the two lines is at Siam station. Most ticket machines only accept coins, but change is available at the information booths.

Bangkok's **MRT** ( 02 354 2000; www.bangkokmetro.co.th), or Metro, is most helpful for people staying in the Sukhumvit or Silom area to reach the train station at Hualamphong.

BUS

Bangkok's public buses are run by the **Bangkok Mass Transit Authority** ( 02 246 0973, call centre 1348; www.bmta.co.th).

As the routes are not always clear, and with Bangkok taxis being such a good deal, you'd really have to be pinching pennies to rely on buses as a way to get around Bangkok. However, if you're determined, air-con bus fares range from 10B to 23B, and fares for fan buses start at 6.50B.

Most of the bus lines run between 5am and 10pm or 11pm, except for the 'all-night' buses, which run from 3am or 4am to mid-morning.

You'll most likely require the help of thinknet's *Bangkok Bus Guide*.

TAXI

All taxis are required to use their meters, which start at 35B, and fares to most places within central Bangkok cost 60B to 90B. Freeway tolls – 25B to 70B – must be paid by the passenger.

Never agree to take a taxi that won't use the meter. If a driver refuses to take you somewhere, it's probably because he needs to return his hired cab before a certain time. Very few Bangkok taxi drivers speak much English, so an address written in Thai is helpful.

Older cabs may be less comfortable but typically have more experienced drivers because they are driver-owned, as opposed to the new cabs, which are usually rented.

Taxi Radio (☎1681; www.taxiradio.co.th) and other 24-hour 'phone-a-cab' services are available for 20B above the metered fare.

If you leave something in a taxi your best chance of getting it back (still pretty slim) is to call ☎1644.



CHAO PHRAYA EXPRESS CRUISES PAST WAT ARUN / MANFRED GOTTSCHALK/GETTY IMAGES

Public Transport at a Glance

BTS The elevated Skytrain runs from 6am to 11.45pm. Tickets 15B to 52B or 140B for a one-day pass.

MRT The metro runs from 6am to midnight. Tickets 16B to 42B or 120B for a one-day pass.

Taxi Outside of rush hours, Bangkok taxis are a great bargain. Flag fall 35B.

Chao Phraya Express Boat Run from 6am to 8pm, charging from 10B to 40B.

Klong boat Bangkok's canal boats run from 5.30am to 7.15pm most days. Tickets from 9B to 19B.

Bus Cheap but slow and confusing. Tickets 6.50B to 30B.

TÚK-TÚK

Bangkok's iconic túk-túk (pronounced *đúk đúk*; a type of motorised rickshaw) are used by Thais for short hops not worth paying the taxi flag fall. For foreigners, however, they are part of the Bangkok experience, despite their inflated prices. The vast majority of túk-túk drivers ask too much from tourists. A short hop should cost 60B.

Túk-túk drivers are notorious for taking little 'detours' to commission-paying gem and silk shops and massage parlours. Ignore anyone offering too-good-to-be-true 20B trips.



TÚK-TÚK TRANSPORT / SYLVAIN SONNET/GETTY IMAGES ©



TAILOR AT WORK / VIVIANE PONTI/GETTY IMAGES ©

Reputable Tailors

Bangkok has fabulous tailors but commission-hungry túk-túk drivers, shoddy workmanship and inferior fabrics make bespoke tailoring in Bangkok a potentially disappointing investment. Most reliable tailors will ask for two to five sittings.

Raja's Fashions [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (☎ 02 253 8379;

www.rajasfashions.com; 160/1 Th Sukhumvit; 🕒 10.30am-8pm Mon-Sat;

📍 Nana exit 4) Bobby will make you feel as important as the long list of ambassadors, foreign politicians and officers he's fitted over his family's decades in the business.

Rajawongse [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (☎ 02 255 3714; [www.dress-for-](http://www.dress-for-success.com)

success.com; 130 Th Sukhumvit; 🕒 10.30am-8pm Mon-Sat; 📍 Nana exit 2) Another legendary and long-standing Bangkok tailor; Jesse

and Victor's creations are particularly renowned among American visitors and residents.

Ricky's Fashion House [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (☎02 254 6887; www.rickysfashionhouse.com; 73/5 Th Sukhumvit; 🕒11am-10pm Mon-Sat & 1-5.30pm Sun; 📍Nana exit 1) Ricky gets positive reviews from locals and resident foreigners alike for his more casual styles of custom-made trousers and shirts.

Nickermann's [MAP](#) [GOOGLE MAP](#) (☎02 252 6682; www.nickermanns.net; basement, Landmark Hotel, 138 Th Sukhumvit; 🕒10am-8.30pm Mon-Sat, noon-6pm Sun; 📍Nana exit 2) Corporate ladies rave about Nickermann's tailor-made power suits. Formal ball gowns are another area of expertise.

BOAT

KLORNG

Canal boats run along Khlong Saen Saep (Banglamphu to Ramkhamhaeng) and are an easy way to get between Banglamphu and Jim Thompson House and the Siam Sq shopping centres. Disembark at Saphan Hua Chang Pier after changing boats at Pratunam Pier.

These boats are mostly used by daily commuters and pull into the piers for just a few seconds – jump straight on or you'll be left behind.

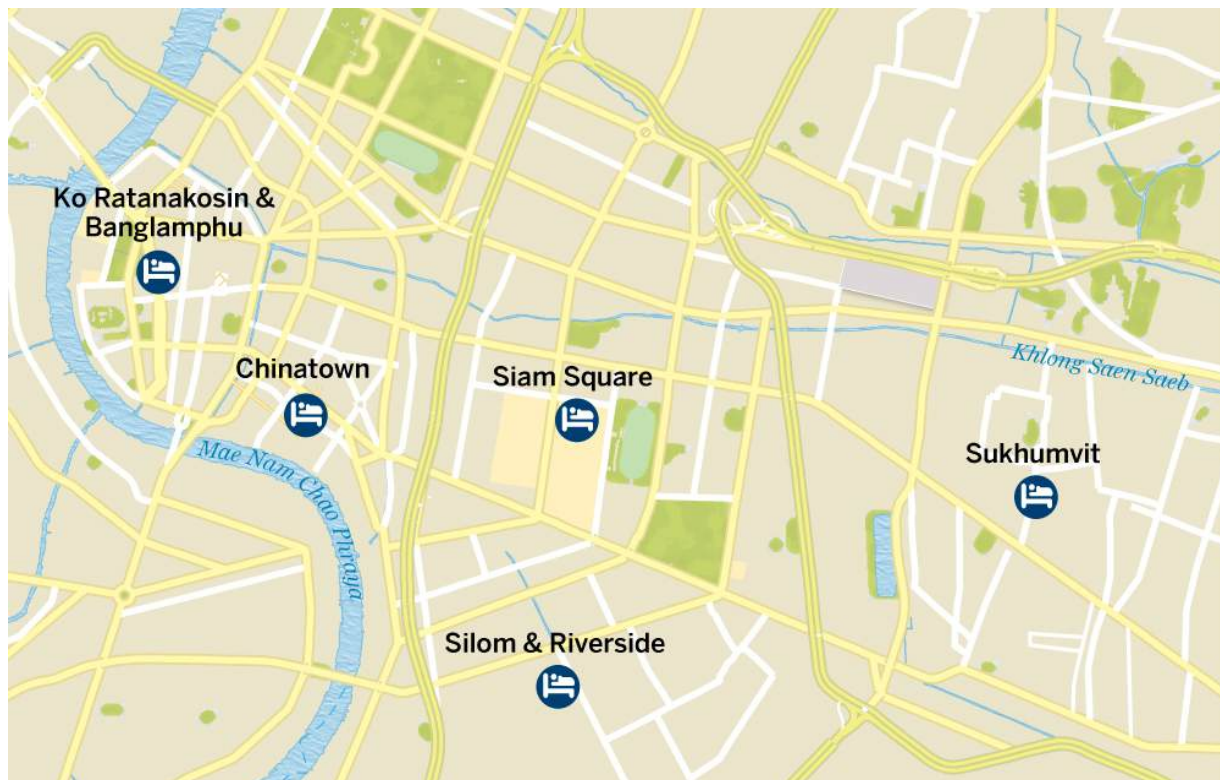
RIVER

The **Chao Phraya Express Boat** (☎02 623 6001; www.chaophrayaexpressboat.com) operates the main ferry service along Mae Nam Chao Phraya. The central pier is known as Tha Sathon, Saphan Taksin or sometimes Central Pier, and connects to the BTS at Saphan Taksin station.

- The most common boats are the orange-flagged express boats. These run between Wat Rajsingkorn, south of Bangkok, to Nonthaburi, north, stopping at most major piers (15B, frequent from 6am to 7pm).
- A blue-flagged tourist boat (40B, half-hourly from 9.30am to 5pm) runs from Sathon/Central Pier to Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier, with stops at eight major sightseeing piers and barely comprehensible English-language commentary. Vendors at Sathon/Central Pier tout a 150B all-day pass, but unless you plan on doing a lot of boat travel, it's not great value.
- There are also dozens of cross-river ferries, which charge 3B and run every few minutes until late at night.
- Private long-tail boats can be hired for sightseeing trips at Phra Athit/Banglamphu Pier, Chang Pier, Tien Pier and Oriental Pier.

Where to Stay

Because Bangkok is a sprawling metropolis, it is best to pick your neighbourhood and then shop within your budget range. Otherwise pick a spot on the BTS for easy neighbourhood hopping.



Neighbourhood	Atmosphere
Ko Ratanakosin & Banglamphu	Close to sights, old-school Bangkok feel; lots of touts and tourists
Chinatown	Interesting budget and midrange options, easy access to sights and train station; noisy and hectic
Siam Square	Convenient access to shopping and BTS; overly commercial; lack of dining and entertainment
Silom & Riverside	Upscale accommodation, convenient to transport, lots of dining and nightlife; noisy and hectic

Sukhumvit

Sophisticated hotels, easy access to BTS and MRT;
international dining and bars; touristy, sexpat hangouts